The Country of Chan City [Champa]

An Account of Central Vietnam from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)
Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

In 1405, the Yongle Emperor (r.1402–1424) initiated the Ming maritime expeditions, dispatching grand armadas under the Muslim eunuch admiral Zheng Ho into the "Western Ocean". Designed to assert diplomatic suzerainty, map coastal trade hubs, and incorporate foreign polities into the imperial tributary system, these voyages represented China's apex as an outward maritime power. Serving as an official Arabic and Persian translator on three separate voyages between 1413 and 1433, Ma Huan recorded firsthand observations that deliberately departed from earlier, myth-laden Chinese geographies.

His record of Chan-ch'eng (the Hindu-Buddhist kingdom of Champa in modern Central Vietnam) preserves a rare snapshot of an Indianized Southeast Asian maritime society operating at a crucial geopolitical turning point. Champa was not merely the first necessary landfall for navigating the South China Sea; it was an embattled kingdom caught between expanding Sinicized Dai Viet in the north and Khmer remnants to the west. Ma Huan documents a complex coastal culture: royal courts governed by Hindu-Buddhist divine-king rituals, economies powered by forest luxuries (ch'ieh-lan eaglewood, ebony, and rhinoceros horn), and a literate administrative class using Sanskrit-derived scripts inscribed upon accordion-folded bark.

Dramatis Personae

- Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official interpreter, traveler, and author of Ying-yai sheng-lan . A Chinese Muslim from Shaoxing versed in foreign scripts who served on the fourth, sixth, and seventh maritime expeditions.
- Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the seven Ming naval expeditions across Southeast Asia, the Indian Ocean, Arabia, and East Africa.
- Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Third emperor of the Ming Dynasty. Architect of early Ming naval expansion who deployed the treasure fleets to manifest dynastic prestige.

- Vira Bhadravarman (Indravarman VI, r. 1400–1441): Cham monarch during Ma Huan's visits, recorded in Chinese annals as paying regular tribute while defending Vijaya against Vietnamese encroachment.
- Xuande Emperor (Zhu Zhanji, r. 1425–1435): Grandson of Yongle who briefly revived overseas voyages in 1430, commissioning the seventh and final grand expedition (1431–1433).
- Wang Ta-yüan (fl. 1330–1350): Yuan-era merchant-traveler whose Tao-i chih-lüeh served as the foundational geographical text against which Ma Huan verified his own observations.
- Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary Ming soldier-scholar on Zheng Ho's fleets who authored Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan (1436), providing parallel records of Champa.
- Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary aboard the seventh voyage whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih corroborates and complements Ma Huan's topographical notes.
- Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Foremost 20th-century Chinese sinologist whose annotated critical collation (chiao-chu) recovered and stabilized the authoritative text of Ma Huan's work.
- J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British jurist, cartographer, and scholar who rendered the definitive English translation and gazetteer for the Hakluyt Society in 1970.

Chronology of the Ming–Cham Maritime Era

- 1368: Accession of the Hongwu Emperor and founding of the Ming Dynasty; formal re-establishment of the tributary system.
- 1390: Cham King Che Bong Nga falls in battle against Dai Viet, shifting the Cham political core south toward Vijaya.
- 1402–1403: Accession of Yongle; construction orders issued for the Longjiang baochuan (treasure-ship) armada.
- 1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho; the armada anchors at Qui Nhon harbor, establishing Champa as China's primary maritime gateway to Southeast Asia.
- 1407: Ming invasion and occupation of Dai Viet (Northern Vietnam); Cham rulers strategically employ Chinese diplomatic ties to counter regional pressures.
- 1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Ma Huan undertakes his first voyage to Champa, cataloging port defenses, royal rituals, and forest aromatics.

- 1424–1425: Death of Yongle; interim Emperor Renzong halts all deep-sea expeditions to curb state expenditure.
- 1427: Ming withdrawal from Northern Vietnam after the uprising of Le Loi, fundamentally altering border security for Champa.
- 1431–1433: Seventh Expedition; the grand fleet makes its final outward assembly in Champa before crossing the Indian Ocean.
- 1436–1451: Circulation and publication of the primary Ming travelogues (Fei Hsin , Kung Chen , and Ma Huan).
- 1471: Fall of the capital Vijaya to Emperor Le Thanh Tong; collapse of northern Cham power and southward displacement toward Panduranga.

PART II: PRIMARY SOURCE TEXT

The Country of Chan City [Champa, Central Vietnam]

Starting from Wu-hu Strait[1] in the Ch'ang-lo district of Fu-chou prefecture in Fu-chien, and travelling south-west, a ship can reach this place in ten days with a fair wind. On the south the country adjoins Chen-la; on the west it connects with the boundary of Chiao-chih; and on both east and north it comes down to the great sea.

At a distance of one hundred li to the north-east from the capital, there is a port named New Department Haven[2]. On the shore they have a stone tower which constitutes a landmark. Ships from all places come here for the purpose of mooring and going ashore. On the shore there is a fort, named by the foreigners She-pi-nai[3]; they have two headmen in charge of it, and inside live fifty or sixty families of foreigners to guard the harbour.

Going south-west for one hundred li, you come to the city where the king resides; its foreign name is Chan city. The city has a wall of stone, with openings at four gates, which men are ordered to guard. The king of the country is a So-li man[4], and a firm believer in the Buddhist religion. On his head he wears a three-tiered, elegantly decorated crown of gold filigree, resembling that worn by the assistants of the ching actors in the Central Country. On his body he wears a long robe of foreign cloth with small designs worked in threads of the five colours, and round the lower part of his body a kerchief of coloured silk; and he has bare feet. When he goes about, he mounts an elephant, or travels riding in a small carriage with two yellow oxen pulling in front.

The hat worn by the chiefs is made of chiao-chang leaves[5], and resembles that worn by the king, but has gold and coloured ornamentation; differences in the hats denote the gradations of rank. The houses in which the king resides are tall and large, roofed with small oblong tiles and enclosed by walls of bricks and mortar. The dwellings of the populace are covered with thatch; the height of the eaves cannot exceed three ch'ih, so that people enter with bowed bodies and lowered heads. White clothing is reserved solely for the king; commoners wear black, yellow, and purple, but wearing white is a capital offence. Both men and women go bare-footed, wrapping the lower body with silk cloths.

The climate is pleasantly hot, without frost or snow, and the plants and trees are always green. The mountains produce ebony, ch'ieh-lan incense[6], Kuan-yin bamboo, and laka-wood. The ch'ieh-lan incense is produced only on one large mountain in this country and comes from no other place in the world; it is very expensive, being exchanged for its own weight in silver. Rhinoceroses and elephants' teeth are very abundant.

Most of the men take up fishing for a livelihood; they seldom go in for agriculture, and therefore rice and cereals are not abundant. The people ceaselessly chew areca-nut and betel-leaf. When men and women marry, the man goes first to the woman's house to consummate the marriage;

ten days or a moon later, the man's relatives escort husband and wife back to the paternal home with drums and music. For writing, they have no paper or pen; they use goat-skin beaten thin or tree-bark smoked black, and write characters with white chalk folded in the form of a classical book[7].

For serious offences, they sever a hand, cut off the nose, or brand the face. For the most heinous crimes, they sharpen a hard wood stake, set it on a wooden log in the water, and impale the offender upon it until death. If in litigation the truth cannot be found, they make the litigants ride water-buffaloes across the crocodile pool [8]; the beasts devour only the unrighteous. When the king has reigned for thirty years, he abdicates to do penance, entering the mountains to fast on a vegetarian diet for one full year; if he survives, he resumes the throne under the holy title Hsi-li Ma-ha-la-cha .

In trading transactions they use pale gold of seventy percent purity, or silver. They are very fond of Chinese blue-and-white porcelain, silk-gauze, and beads, tendering their native aromatics, ivory, and rhinoceros horns as tribute to the Central Country.

PART III: EDITORIAL APPARATUS (FOOTNOTES)

- Wu-hu Strait (Five Tigers Pass): The primary navigational outlet at the estuary of the Min River in Fujian Province, where the imperial fleets gathered and anchored while awaiting the winter northeast monsoon.
- New Department Haven (Hsin-chou): The Chinese maritime designation for Qui Nhon bay (13°46′N, 109°14′E), the foremost natural harbor servicing the Cham capital.
- She-pi-nai (Sri Banoy): The fortified coastal citadel (identified with the Binh-lam archaeological site) guarding the inland passage between the sea and the Cham administrative interior.
- So-li (Chola): Used broadly by Ming travelers to denote southern Indian lineages, referencing the historic Indianization of Cham court institutions, royalty, and religious rituals.
- Chiao-chang (Kajang): A Cham/Malay term for waterproof matting woven from the dried leaves of the screw-pine (Pandanus), used widely across maritime Southeast Asia for headgear, awnings, and walls.
- Ch'ieh-lan (Calambac): The highest grade of fragrant agarwood/eaglewood (Aquilaria agallocha), valued by the imperial court and exchanged on par with refined silver.
- Accordion Books (Pustaka): Bark-cloth paper or smoked palm/goat skins folded in accordion format, derived from Indian manuscript traditions and inscribed with a chalk or steatite stylus.
- Crocodile Ordeal: A classical Indianized judicial ordeal (divya) practiced across Southeast Asia, predicated on divine intervention where riverine beasts punish only the guilty party.

The Country of Chao-wa [Java]

An Account of Majapahit Society from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)
Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth century, the maritime armadas commanded by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho made repeated, extended layovers along the northern coast of eastern Java. At this juncture, the island was dominated by the Hindu-Buddhist realm of Majapahit, then experiencing its twilight under Queen Suhita (r.1429–1447) following devastating succession crises. Because imperial fleets regularly awaited the shifting seasonal monsoons in Javanese ports, Chinese chroniclers had unprecedented access to the region's inner workings. Serving as an official translator, Ma Huan recorded a comprehensive portrait of the island's economic power, religious landscape, and urban topography. His chapter on Java captures a dynamic multi-ethnic society divided into three distinct communities: foreign Muslim merchants from the West, newly established Chinese immigrant diasporas from Guangdong and Zhangzhou, and the indigenous population governed by Indic rituals. Ma Huan notes the widespread circulation of Chinese copper coinage, the prevalence of palm-leaf (lontar) literature, and the pervasive culture of honor centered around the krisdagger. The text provides an invaluable baseline documenting the critical transition period between the zenith of Hindu-Javanese court civilization and the rapid emergence of coastal Islamic sultanates across the archipelago.

Dramatis Personae

- Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official interpreter, Chinese Muslim, and author of Ying-yai sheng-lan , who accompanied three voyages under Zheng Ho and closely examined eastern Java.
- Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Imperial Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions whose fleets berthed at Tuban and Surabaya.
- Queen Suhita (r. 1429–1447): Sovereign of the Majapahit Empire during Ma Huan's final visit in 1432, reigning after the destructive Paregreg civil war.
- Wikramawardhana (r. 1389–1429): Preceding king of Majapahit whose reign saw early diplomatic contact with the Yongle Emperor's naval armadas.
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- Raden Wijaya (Kertarajasa Jayawardhana, r. 1293–1309): Founder of Majapahit, who repelled the Yuan invasion fleet and established the capital at Trowulan.

- Shih Pi and Kao Hsing (fl. 1292–1293): Yuan Dynasty expeditionary commanders whose failed invasion of Java is recalled in local legends regarding the "Holy Water" spring at Tuban.
- Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary expedition scholar whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan confirms the social stratification and martial customs observed in Javanese ports.
- Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Fleet secretary whose account (Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih) supplements Ma Huan with precise details on royal carriage processions and attire.
- Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Leading 20th-century Chinese sinologist whose critical collation established the authoritative modern edition of Ma Huan's travelogue.
- J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British jurist, cartographer, and scholar who produced the definitive English translation and maritime commentary for the Hakluyt Society in 1970.

Chronology of the Majapahit–Ming Era

- 1293: Khubilai Khan's Mongol-Chinese invasion force lands in eastern Java; Raden Wijaya outmaneuvers the imperial forces, founding the kingdom of Majapahit.
- 1350–1389: Golden age of Majapahit under King Hayam Wuruk and Prime Minister Gajah Mada; maritime hegemony expands across the Indonesian archipelago.
- 1401–1406: The Paregreg War; internal civil conflict severely weakens Majapahit royal central authority.
- 1405–1407: First Expedition of Zheng Ho; Chinese naval squadrons establish permanent seasonal depots along Java's northern coast.
- 1406: Ming emissaries caught in eastern Java during civil fighting; the imperial court exacts monetary indemnities while maintaining diplomatic ties.
- 1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Ma Huan explores the ports of Tuban, Gresik, and Surabaya, traveling inland to the royal capital.
- 1429: Accession of Queen Suhita to the Majapahit throne.
- 1432: Seventh Expedition calls at Surabaya; Ma Huan records the culmination of his Javanese observations.
- 1451: Compilation and initial circulation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .
- 1478–1527: Rise of the Islamic coastal sultanate of Demak; progressive collapse of the Majapahit interior kingdom.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

- She-p'o (Java): The traditional Chinese designation for the island of Java, derived from earlier Sanskrit and regional designations (Yavadvipa).
- Tuban (Tu-pan): Major fortified port on the northern coast of East Java, serving as the earliest commercial gateway and disembarkation point for maritime travelers.

- Gresik (Tse-ts'un / New Village): Important trading town founded primarily by overseas Chinese merchants in the late fourteenth century, flourishing as an international spice-trading center.
- Canggu (Chang-ku): An essential riverine transshipment port on the Kali Mas, where shallow drafts conveyed passengers traveling between coastal ports and the inland capital.
- Majapahit (Man-che-po-i): The imperial capital of the realm, situated inland near modern Trowulan, surrounded by brick compounds and royal pavilions.
- Pu-la-t'ou (Kris / Beladau): The indigenous double-edged wavy or curved dagger worn universally by men as a sacred emblem of status, identity, and personal defense.
- Three Classes of Inhabitants: Ma Huan's early sociological taxonomy identifying Western Muslim merchants, Chinese diaspora communities, and native animist/Hindu-Buddhist populations.
- Wayang Beber: An ancient Javanese dramatic tradition utilizing illustrated paper or cloth scrolls unrolled horizontally while a narrator (dalang) chants epic stories.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Approach and the Four Settlements

The realm of Java, historically termed She-p'o by Chinese annalists, encompassed four principal urban centers linked by maritime and riverine trade networks. Ships arriving from foreign seas made initial landfall at the northern harbor of Tuban, before sailing eastward toward the merchant community of Gresik (termed New Village by Chinese traders). Continuing south, vessels reached the protected estuary of Surabaya, which served as the terminal anchorage for deep-draft sea-going treasure ships. To reach the political core of the realm, travelers transferred to small riverboats, ascending the Kali Mas to the river landing of Canggu. From this river station, a land journey to the southwest brought visitors directly to the royal capital of Majapahit, where the ruler and court elite resided within expansive brick-walled enclosures.

Court Hierarchy, Royal Palaces, and Material Culture

The palace of the sovereign was constructed with tall brick masonry walls rising over thirty feet, enclosed by double security gates and manicured gardens. Royal halls and residential chambers were built with raised wooden platforms supported by massive timber posts, roofed with split hardwood shingles or fired tiles, and carpeted with fine patterned rattan mats. Commoners' residences, by contrast, relied entirely on thatch roofing and were restricted by customary law to low eaves.

The monarch wore long unkempt hair or ornate golden flower crowns, draped in silk brocades and sash cloths without formal tunics, walking barefoot in accordance with sacred Indic norms. When moving through the realm, the sovereign traveled upon caparisoned elephants or in ceremonial wooden carriages pulled by yellow oxen. Noble chiefs wore head coverings crafted from folded pandanus leaves, using gold ornamentation to denote administrative seniority.

Social Composition and Demographics

Ma Huan observed that the population of eastern Java was stratified into three primary cultural communities:

- Muslim Merchants from the West: Foreign traders arriving from India, Persia, and the Middle East, who resided in coastal commercial districts, adhered strictly to Islamic dietary practices, and wore clean, distinctive attire.
- Chinese Settlers: Immigrants largely hailing from Guangdong and Fujian (specifically Zhangzhou and Quanzhou) who had established permanent mercantile families; many had embraced Islam while maintaining active trade ties with arriving Chinese vessels.
- Indigenous Inhabitants: The native majority, described by early Chinese chroniclers as following ancient local deities and animistic cults alongside Hindu-Buddhist traditions. They went barefoot, wore unkempt hair, and carried distinctive customs regarding diet, social taboos, and ceremonial combat.

Martial Customs, Law, and the Culture of the Dagger

Every male, from young boys of three years to elderly men, carried at his waist the distinctive steel dagger (pu-la-t'ou, corresponding to the Malay-Javanese krisor beladau). These blades were crafted from pattern-welded crucible steel, adorned with fine Damascus veins and mounted in handles carved from rhinoceros horn, elephant ivory, or gold with intricate effigies. Men held extreme sensitivity regarding personal honor and physical boundaries; touching another person's head was considered a grave provocation that prompted instantaneous retaliation.

Disputes over trade or insults often provoked fatal duels. Rather than utilizing corporal punishment such as flogging, the legal system imposed capital punishment with extreme frequency. Condemned criminals had their arms bound with rattan and were marched to secluded execution grounds, where officials dispatched them by thrusting sharp blades directly beneath the ribs into the heart.

Tournaments, Domestic Life, and Funeral Rites

Annually, during the turn of the seasons, the kingdom staged massive bamboo lance tournaments (Senenan). Royal women, including the queen, watched from elevated carriages as mounted or foot warriors engaged in ritual combat, charging at one another with blunted spears while wives and female attendants stood ready to separate the fighters upon signal drums.

Marriage rituals required the prospective husband to reside initially at the bride's household, consummating the union before being escorted back to his paternal home amid drum music, gong processions, and betel offerings. Funeral customs varied between exposure to wild dogs along coastal strands, river burials, and full cremation. Among high-ranking nobles and wives of the aristocratic class, the practice of suttee was prevalent: favorite concubines and personal

attendants took sacred vows to follow their lord into the afterlife, leaping into funeral pyres constructed of resinous timber.

Economy, Measurements, and Performing Arts

Java functioned as a thriving maritime emporium. Because local agriculture flourished on irrigated terraces, double-cropped paddy fields yielded abundant harvests of small-grain rice, which the kingdom exported widely to spice-producing islands and Malacca. In exchange for Chinese blue-and-white porcelain, musk, and silks, Java supplied nutmeg, white sandalwood, sapan-wood, long pepper, and pearls. The standard currency used in everyday domestic trade was Chinese cast copper coins (cash), which circulated alongside local weighing measures based on the kulakand kobang . Scribes recorded legal decrees and literary compositions on dried palm leaves (lontar) using sharp metal styluses.

Ma Huan highlighted popular cultural pastimes, including nocturnal choral walks under the full moon and narrative performances by scroll-singers (Wayang Beber). During these shows, a seated performer unrolled illustrated paper paintings mounted on wooden rods, chanting historical and mythic tales with dramatic vocal modulations that captivated large village gatherings.

The Country of Old Haven [Palembang]

An Account of Sumatra's Riverine Emporium from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages commanded by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the Musi River port of Palembang (termed Chiu-chiang or "Old Haven" by Chinese navigators) served as a vital strategic station linking the Java Sea with the Strait of Malacca. Originally the seat of the once-dominant Buddhist maritime thalassocracy of Srivijaya (San-fo-ch'i), by the late fourteenth century the region had fallen under the suzerainty of the East Javanese empire of Majapahit before degenerating into an autonomous outpost dominated by overseas Chinese armed fleets. Ma Huan's account documents a pivotal historical intervention: during the first expedition (1405–1407), the Ming armada forcibly subdued the entrenched Chinese pirate syndicate commanded by Chen Zuyi, executing its leadership and establishing an imperial pacification bureau under a recognized local Chinese merchant headman, Shih Chin-ch'ing. Ma Huan captures a unique amphibious urban environment where commoners lived upon floating timber rafts, local warriors specialized in riverine boat warfare, and lucrative trades in resinous aromatics, exotic avians, and forest goods were transacted using Ming copper currency.

Dramatis Personae

- Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Expedition interpreter and chronicler whose records describe the geography, river settlements, and administrative history of Palembang.
- Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions, who led the military defeat and capture of Chen Zuyi's fleet at Palembang in 1407.
- Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who sanctioned military suppression of piracy in Southeast Asian waters and formalized Palembang as a Chinese tributary protectorate.
- Chen Zuyi (Ch'en Tsu-i, d. 1407): Prominent Chinese pirate chieftain from Guangdong who seized de facto control of Palembang, plundering foreign merchant shipping until captured by Zheng Ho and executed at Nanjing.
- Shih Chin-ch'ing (d. c. 1424): Chinese merchant and local leader in Palembang who cooperated with Zheng Ho against Chen Zuyi, subsequently invested by the Ming court as the hereditary Pacification Commissioner.
- Shih Erh-chieh (fl. 1424–1433): Daughter of Shih Chin-ch'ing who succeeded to authority as ruler of the Palembang community, wielding power over civil justice, taxation, and appointments.

- Shih Chi-sun (fl. 1424): Son of Shih Chin-ch'ing who petitioned the imperial court for confirmation of administrative titles after his father's death.
- Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Fleet contemporary whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan records complementary details regarding local flora, fauna, and tributary items from Sumatra.
- Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Leading sinologist and historical geographer who edited and annotated the composite text of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .
- J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar who produced the definitive Hakluyt Society critical edition and English translation of the Ming expeditions.

Chronology of Old Haven / Srivijaya

- 671–695: Chinese pilgrim Yijing studies in Srivijaya (Palembang), recording it as a major international center of Buddhist scholarship and maritime trade.
- 1025: Chola naval raids from southern India strike Palembang and its dependencies, initiating the gradual political decentralization of Srivijaya.
- 1377: Majapahit forces conquer and sack Palembang, extinguishing the old royal lineage; large communities of Chinese merchants from Guangdong and Fujian settle in the power vacuum.
- c. 1390s: Chen Zuyi flees China during the Hongwu reign, establishes an armed stronghold at Palembang, and terrorizes regional sea lanes.
- 1407: Zheng Ho's armada defeats Chen Zuyi's fleet, killing thousands of raiders; Chen Zuyi is transported to Nanjing for execution, and Shih Chin-ch'ing is appointed local administrator.
- 1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Ma Huan visits Palembang, cataloging its riverine raft settlements and natural forest products.
- 1424–1425: Death of Shih Chin-ch'ing; authority is assumed by his daughter Shih Erh-chieh, who continues diplomatic and tributary missions to China.
- 1432: Seventh Expedition calls at the mouth of the Musi River en route from Java to Malacca.
- 1451: Compilation and publication of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

- Chiu-chiang (Old Haven): The Chinese maritime name for Palembang, derived from its location along the Musi River estuary in southern Sumatra.
- San-fo-ch'i (Srivijaya): The historic classical polity encompassing southeastern Sumatra; though politically fragmented by the 15th century, the name persisted in Chinese geographical records.
- Musi River Estuary (Fresh Water Estuary): The wide tidal mouth connecting the Bangka Strait to Palembang, navigated by smaller river craft while ocean vessels anchored seaward.
- Raft Dwellings: Amphibious architectural structures constructed from lashed timber logs tethered to riverbank posts, rising and falling with the massive daily tidal fluctuations.
- Crane's Crest Bird (Helmeted Hornbill): Rhinoplax vigil , sought for its dense, carvable red-and-yellow keratinous casque, widely used in East Asian luxury lapidary work.

- Fire Fowl (Cassowary): Casuarius , an exotic flightless bird imported via regional island trade networks from eastern Indonesia (such as Ceram) and gifted to travelers.
- Mysterious Deer (Malayan Tapir): Tapirus indicus , an indigenous herbivore of the lowland Sumatran rainforests, described accurately by Ma Huan by its distinctive black-and-white coloration.
- Chin-yin Incense (Benzoin): A high-value aromatic resin harvested from the Styrax tree (kemenyan), burned in imperial rituals and used extensively as an export luxury.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographical Situation and the River Route

The kingdom known to Chinese navigators as Old Haven (Chiu-chiang) occupied the site of ancient Srivijaya (San-fo-ch'i), situated along the southeastern seaboard of Sumatra. Recognized regionally by the local designation P'o-lin-pang , the realm recognized the nominal suzerainty of East Java's Majapahit kingdom. Geographically, the sea lay to its north, towering mountain ranges rose to its south, the sea route toward Java extended to the east, while Malacca bordered it to the west.

Oceanic shipping approaching from abroad traversed the Bangka Strait to enter the great tidal mouth of the Musi River. Along the seaward coastline stood prominent brick towers serving as navigational guides for approaching mariners. Due to shallowing water and river bars, large ocean vessels anchored in the outer roads, while passengers, crews, and cargo transferred to light river craft to journey upstream to the capital settlement.

Urban Settlement and Amphibious Society

A large proportion of the city's inhabitants were Chinese emigrants from Guangdong and the Zhangzhou and Quanzhou prefectures of Fujian, who had fled overseas during the early Ming reign to establish trading households. The community was prosperous, enriched by fertile surrounding soils where local agricultural sayings noted that sowing grain in a single season yielded harvests across three successive periods.

Because dry firm land was scarce along the swampy, mangrove-fringed riverbanks, the common populace constructed their homes upon broad timber rafts tied to mooring posts driven into the mud. When the daily ocean tides surged into the river twice a day, these floating houses rose with the water without suffering flood damage. If a family wished to relocate, they untied the mooring ropes and let the current carry their residence elsewhere without difficulty. Only the local headmen and wealthy merchants maintained permanent brick and timber compounds on dry ground along the banks. The customs, clothing, food, and marriage rites closely mirrored those of Java, and the inhabitants showed great enthusiasm for gaming, cock-fighting, and board games. In military matters, the population possessed expert proficiency in aquatic and riverine warfare.

The Pirate Stronghold and Ming Restoration

During the Hongwu era, an armed leader named Chen Zuyi fled from Guangdong with his family and followers, seizing dominance over the Palembang haven. Operating with naval impunity, Chen plundered passing commercial fleets and imposed tyrannical levies on travelers.

When Zheng Ho's grand armada arrived during the first voyage (1405–1407), another prominent Chinese resident, Shih Chin-ch'ing, reported the pirate confederacy's depredations to the imperial envoys. In the ensuing confrontation, Ming marines and war junks engaged Chen Zuyi's fleet, killing thousands of brigands, capturing several pirate vessels, and taking Chen captive. Escorted back to China, Chen was publicly executed at Nanjing.

In recognition of his loyalty, the imperial court invested Shih Chin-ch'ing with a ceremonial hat, sash, and official credentials, confirming him as principal pacification chief over Old Haven. Following Shih Chin-ch'ing's death, governance passed to his capable daughter, Shih Erh-chieh, who exercised full executive authority over appointments, rewards, and legal punishments while maintaining regular tributary embassies to China.

Commodities, Fauna, and Market Trade

Old Haven functioned as an active trading post for rare forest and maritime commodities:

- Aromatics and Resins: The country yielded high-grade laka-wood, sinking eaglewood, and fragrant benzoin (chin-yinincense), an aromatic resin prized for silver inlaying and sacred offerings.
- Avian Rarities: The forests produced the helmeted hornbill (the "crane's crest bird"), whose thick, carmine-colored cranial bone was carved into archers' rings, snuff boxes, and dagger hilts; travelers also encountered the flightless cassowary ("fire fowl"), renowned for its sharp plumage and defensive claws.
- Fauna: Upland tracts sheltered the Malayan tapir, described by Ma Huan as an unusual pig-like beast with a starkly divided black-and-white coat that fed exclusively on wild leaves and plant shoots. Domestic stocks included cattle, goats, pigs, and ducks.

In urban marketplaces, trade was transacted with Chinese copper coins (cash) alongside silks and fine cloth, with local rulers continuously dispatching vessels laden with tribute to the Ming court.

The Country of Hsien Lo [Siam / Thailand]

An Account of the Ayutthaya Kingdom from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth century, the maritime expeditions commanded by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho established sustained diplomatic and commercial ties with mainland Southeast Asia. At this juncture, the central plains of Thailand were dominated by the Kingdom of Ayutthaya, known in Chinese records as Hsien Lo following the consolidation of the northern Tai state of Sukhothai (Hsien) and the southern Mon-Khmer center of Lavo (Lo-hu). As an official interpreter, Ma Huan recorded the material conditions, social structures, and administrative life of the kingdom. His narrative highlights Ayutthaya's active riverine commerce, centered around the Chao Phraya basin and the upriver market of Lopburi (Shang-shui), while detailing the prominence of Theravada Buddhist monasticism, legal systems, and distinctive sumptuary norms. Ma Huan also provides valuable early ethnographic documentation of the prominent role of women in commerce and household administration, distinctive body modifications, local currency systems utilizing cowries, and maritime tributary exchanges with the Ming court.

Dramatis Personae

- Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official interpreter, Chinese Muslim from Shaoxing, and author of Ying-yai sheng-lan .
- Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming maritime expeditions.
- Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who initiated the naval voyages and formalized tributary relations with Ayutthaya.
- King Ramaracha (r. 1395–1409) / Intharacha (r. 1409–1424): Monarchs of Ayutthaya during the early Ming expeditions, maintaining active tributary embassies to China.
- Borommarachathirat II (r. 1424–1448): Ruler of Ayutthaya during the later Ming voyages, noted for expanding Siamese authority over Angkor and neighboring peninsular polities.
- Wang Ta-yüan (fl. 1330–1350): Yuan-era merchant-traveler whose Tao-i chih-lüeh recorded earlier independent notices of Hsien and Lo-hu .
- Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary scholar-soldier whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan provides parallel observations of Siam's fertile terrain and commercial commodities.
- Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Fleet secretary whose work Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih corroborates details regarding Siamese marital customs, clothing, and domestic practices.
- Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Leading 20th-century Chinese sinologist who critically collated and annotated the extant versions of Ma Huan's text.

- J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who prepared the definitive Hakluyt Society critical edition and gazetteer.

3. Chronology of the Ayutthaya–Ming Era

- 1350: King Ramathibodi I founds the Ayutthaya Kingdom on the Chao Phraya River, unifying the central Menam basin.
- 1370–1371: First official diplomatic missions exchanged between the newly founded Ming Dynasty and the court of Ayutthaya.
- 1403: The Yongle Emperor confirms the formal title of the realm as Hsien Lo , acknowledging its unified status.
- 1407–1409: Second Expedition under Zheng Ho's associates visits Siam to bestow imperial gifts and ratify tributary ties.
- 1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Chinese commercial and diplomatic emissaries trade in the capital and visit Lopburi.
- 1421–1422: Sixth Expedition calls at Siamese coastal ports during its homeward voyage.
- 1431: Siamese forces besiege Angkor Thom, accelerating the collapse of the Khmer Empire and expanding Ayutthaya's regional influence.
- 1436–1451: Publication and circulation of the primary Ming travelogues describing Siamese customs (Fei Hsin , Kung Chen , and Ma Huan).

4. Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

- Hsien Lo (Siam / Thailand): The standard Chinese designation formed by combining Hsien (Sukhothai) and Lo-hu (Lavo / Lopburi).
- New Strait Towers (Hsin-men-t'ai): The fortified estuarine anchorage at the river mouths of the Chao Phraya and Mae Klong rivers guarding the approach to Ayutthaya.
- Upper Water (Shang-shui): Identified with Lopburi (Lavo), an inland river port roughly 25 miles north of Ayutthaya, frequented by Chinese merchants.
- Theravada Monasticism: Ma Huan highlights the pervasive presence of Buddhist monks and nuns, noting their orange habits, strict fasting, and monastic disciplines.
- Matrilocal Marriage Customs: Marital arrangements where the husband initially entered the bride's domestic residence following consummation, accompanied by music and feasts.
- Bird-Burial (Niao-tsang): A traditional funerary practice for commoners involving the exposure of corpses along beaches or open clearings to birds of prey, followed by the collection and casting of bones into rivers.
- Cowry Currency (Hai-pa): Shells of marine cowries utilized as small-denomination currency in local market transactions alongside gold and silver ingots.
- Sapan-Wood (Su-mu): The heartwood of Caesalpinia sappan , a major Siamese export commodity heavily harvested for red textile dyeing and medicinal use.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Approach and Coastal Navigation

Sailing southwest across the sea from Qui Nhon in Champa for seven days with a favorable wind brought ships to the maritime approaches of Siam. Entering the shallow waters near the river estuary at New Strait Towers, vessels anchored in sheltered roadsteads before smaller craft navigated the inland waterways toward the royal capital at Ayutthaya. Ma Huan notes that the outer frontiers of the kingdom were bordered by rugged hills, while the inland basin consisted of low-lying floodplains subject to seasonal inundation.

The Capital, Monarchy, and Monastic Culture

The royal palace at Ayutthaya featured clean, orderly enclosures, while the dwellings of commoners were raised on wooden piles using areca-palm flooring and thatch roofing. The monarch, described as adhering devoutly to the Buddhist faith, wore white cloth wrappings on his head, draped his shoulders in embroidered silks, and traveled mounted atop elephants or in sedan-chairs sheltered by gilded umbrellas.

Theravada Buddhism occupied a central place in the civic and religious life of the kingdom. Monks and nuns were numerous, wearing simple robes and residing in extensive monastery complexes where they engaged in daily recitations, fasting, and austere disciplines. In civic affairs, women exercised substantial autonomy and managed the majority of commercial negotiations and domestic financial decisions, earning praise from Chinese observers for their enterprise and intellectual capability.

Social Customs, Domestic Rites, and Funerary Practices

Marriages were arranged with the assistance of Buddhist priests, who escorted the groom to the household of the bride's parents. Following the initial consummation at her family's dwelling, the groom's kin organized processions with decorated boats, feast preparations, and musical accompaniment to conduct the couple back home.

Funerary customs reflected social station. Wealthy families preserved the remains of deceased relatives with quicksilver before subterranean burial. Commoners, by contrast, carried their dead to coastal sands or wild outskirts, leaving the remains exposed to large scavenger birds in a practice termed "bird-burial". Once the flesh was consumed, the surviving kin gathered the bones, conducted Buddhist liturgies, and consigned the remains to the river currents.

Inland Trade at Lopburi and Market Commodities

Roughly sixty miles north of the royal capital lay the bustling inland trading center of Lopburi (Shang-shui), accessible by river craft. This market town hosted hundreds of foreign merchant households and served as a major transshipment hub for valuable forest goods, including gemstones, cardamoms, chaulmoogra seeds, dragon's-blood resin, and laka-wood. In exchange, Chinese traders offered cast iron pans, ceramics, and silk-gauze textiles.

Sapan-wood was exceedingly plentiful throughout the forested hills, cut into logs and exported in enormous quantities for use as kindling and red dye. In local marketplaces, transactions were conducted primarily through cowry shells (hai-pa), though uncoined gold, silver, and cast copper were also weighed for major transactions, while the kingdom maintained an uninterrupted flow of tributary missions presenting native luxuries to the Chinese court.

The Country of Man-la-chia [Malacca]

An Account of the Strait Emporium from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

1. Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth century, the rise of the Melaka Sultanate transformed regional navigation and commerce across maritime Southeast Asia. Prior to its imperial elevation, the settlement—known in early Chinese records as the Five Islands (Wu-hsü)—was a subordinate coastal territory forced to pay tribute under threat of invasion from Ayutthaya. In 1409, during the third expedition of Admiral Zheng Ho, the Ming court formally elevated Malacca to the status of an independent kingdom, conferring royal regalia, official seals, and a stone inscription upon its founder, Parameswara (later Sultan Iskandar Shah). Ma Huan's account provides an essential view of this strategic port city at the height of the Ming tributary relationship. He details the establishment of a fortified Chinese cantonment (kuan-ch'ang) that served as a central logistics base, transshipment storehouse, and rendezvous depot for treasure fleets dispersing across the Indian Ocean and assembling for the return voyage. Ma Huan also documents the emergence of Islamic institutions, riverine marketplace infrastructure, indigenous tin-block currencies, forest resources, and regional fauna.

2. Dramatis Personae

- Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official interpreter, Chinese Muslim scholar from Shaoxing, and chronicler who observed Malacca firsthand on multiple voyages.
- Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions, who established the Malacca depot and presented imperial recognition to its sovereign.
- Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who granted imperial protection to Malacca, elevating its status to deter Siamese incursions.
- Parameswara (Sultan Iskandar Shah, d. 1414): Founder of the Melaka Sultanate who traveled to the Ming court in 1411 to render homage and secure political backing.
- Sri Maharaja (r. 1424–1444): Second ruler of Malacca (Raja Tengah), who maintained close diplomatic missions and personally journeyed to China in 1433.
- Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary soldier-scholar on the expeditions whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan corroborates Malacca's defensive stockade and tributary trade.
- Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih supplements descriptions of Malacca's river bridge and foreign warehouses.
- Wang Ta-yüan (fl. 1330–1350): Fourteenth-century merchant whose earlier travelogue recorded peninsular navigation points prior to Malacca's founding.

- Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Leading sinologist and historical geographer whose critical collation stabilized the surviving texts of Ma Huan's work.
- J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who produced the annotated Hakluyt Society edition of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

3. Chronology of the Melaka–Ming Era

- c. 1400–1402: Parameswara flees Temasek (Singapore) and founds the trading settlement of Malacca along the Bertam River.
- 1403: Ming envoy Yin Qing arrives in Malacca, initiating initial diplomatic ties.
- 1405: Parameswara dispatches his first tributary mission to Nanjing; the Yongle Emperor recognizes him as ruler.
- 1409: Zheng Ho's third expedition visits Malacca, erecting an imperial tablet and formally proclaiming it a kingdom.
- 1411: The King of Malacca, accompanied by his family and ministers, visits China aboard Ming vessels to render homage.
- 1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Ma Huan observes the operation of the fortified Chinese transit depot at Malacca.
- 1424: Accession of Sri Maharaja; ongoing tributary missions sent to Peking.
- 1431–1433: Seventh Expedition; the grand armada reassembles at Malacca before embarking on the homeward run to China.
- 1451: Circulation and compilation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .
- 1511: Portuguese forces under Afonso de Albuquerque capture Malacca, ending the sultanate's rule over the city.

4. Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

- Five Islands (Wu-hsü): Early Chinese nautical designation for the coastal area and the Water Islands (Pulau Besar cluster) off the harbor of Malacca.
- Lung-ya Strait (Lingga / Singapore Strait): The vital waterway between the southern tip of the Malay Peninsula and the Riau-Lingga archipelago, guiding ships entering the Strait of Malacca.
- The River Bridge: A wooden structure spanning the Malacca River lined with over twenty trading booths where international exchange was conducted.
- Chinese Cantonment (Kuan-ch'ang): A double-stockaded logistics depot with watchtowers and granaries built by Zheng Ho's forces to store supplies and secure trade goods.
- Tin Block Currency: Cast ingots of tin (timah) poured into small and large measured weights, functioning as a primary medium of exchange in local markets.
- Dammar (Ta-ma-erh): A natural tree resin collected from dipterocarp forests, widely used as pitch for caulking ocean vessels and burning in lamps.
- Sago (Sha-ku): Starch extracted from the sago palm trunk, prepared into meal or dried cakes to supplement the diet in grain-scarce coastal zones.
- Were-Tigers and Forest Spirits: Local folklore recorded by Ma Huan describing human metamorphosis into tigers and nocturnal predatory spirits (Hantu).

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Position and Political Elevation

Malacca was situated along the western coast of the Malay Peninsula, positioned across the strait from northern Sumatra. Ships sailing south from Champa traversed the waters past the Singapore straits before turning westward to enter the port. The coastline faced the sea to the southwest, while dense jungle and rugged ranges lay inland to the north and east.

Originally, the settlement lacked royal status and was known among maritime traders as the Five Islands. Ruled by a local chieftain, the community was subject to the hegemony of Siam, yielding an annual tributary payment of forty ounces of gold under threat of armed raids. During the early Yongle period, the Ming court intervened, dispatching Admiral Zheng Ho with imperial edicts, royal insignia, and a memorial stone tablet to elevate the chieftain to the rank of king. Strengthened by Chinese imperial protection, the newly founded kingdom ceased paying tribute to Siam and became a sovereign maritime power. The monarch subsequently journeyed to the imperial court in China to present local tribute and express gratitude for imperial investiture.

Urban Infrastructure and the Chinese Depot

The port town developed around the mouth of the Malacca River. Across the water, the king constructed a substantial wooden bridge lined with more than twenty covered booths where merchants gathered daily to barter goods.

Whenever the Ming treasure ships arrived, Chinese officers established a heavily fortified transit cantonment surrounded by a double line of palisades and watchtowers. Within these stockades, armed sentries struck night watches, while expansive storehouses and granaries protected provisions, precious metals, and trade goods. When secondary squadrons detached from the main fleet sailed to India, Arabia, or Africa, they returned to this depot, waiting in safety until the favorable southwest monsoon allowed the combined armada to set sail for China.

Religion, Attire, and Domestic Society

The ruler, administrative chiefs, and populace adhered to the Islamic faith, observing daily prayers, fasting, and ceremonial liturgies. The monarch wore fine white headcloths, flowing robes of patterned blue fabric, and soft leather footwear, traveling through the town in wooden sedan-chairs. The common people wrapped their heads in cloth squares, wore short coats, and secured cotton waistcloths (sarongs) around their bodies.

Domestic residences were constructed on raised piles several feet above the ground, using split coconut timber for floors and woven mats of screw-pine leaves (kajang) for roofs and partitions. Agriculture was limited due to sandy and saline soils, prompting the community to rely on fishing, coastal foraging, and imported rice from Sumatra and Java. To supplement their sustenance, the populace processed the pulp of sago trees into edible flour cakes.

Commodities, Currency, and Regional Commerce

Malacca's economy centered on its position as an international transshipment center and exporter of local jungle goods:

- Tin Mining and Currency: In the interior valleys, miners panned tin ore and smelted the metal into standardized cast blocks that served as the kingdom's primary currency in market stalls.
- Resins and Aromatics: Forest collectors gathered high-grade yellow incense, eaglewood, and copious quantities of tree pitch (dammar), which was purchased by visiting fleets to seal ship hulls and ignite torches.
- Regional Fauna and Lore: The surrounding rivers and coasts harbored large saltwater crocodiles, while the rainforests sheltered leopards, black panthers, and tigers. Ma Huan noted local traditions concerning were-tigers who allegedly infiltrated towns in human guise before transforming into predators.

Malacca maintained continuous commercial and diplomatic contact with China, regularly loading local aromatics, foreign imports, and tribute gifts onto ships bound for the Ming court.

The Country of Ya-lu [Aru / Deli]

An Account of East Sumatra from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century naval expeditions led by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the kingdom of Aru (Ya-lu , centered along the Deli River basin in northeastern Sumatra) represented an important regional coastal polity along the Strait of Malacca. Situated between the rising commercial power of Malacca to the east and the major regional hub of Semudera-Pasai to the west, Aru provided Ming navigators with an accessible riverine anchorage along the eastern Sumatran coastline. As an official interpreter serving aboard the treasure fleet, Ma Huan documented the small kingdom's geographical setting, social composition, and natural resources. His account describes an agrarian and fishing populace professing the Muslim faith and sharing linguistic, marital, and funerary traditions with the broader Malayu-Javanese sphere. In addition to local agricultural staples such as dry-land rice and livestock, Ma Huan records the export of upland forest luxuries—most notably fragrant laka-wood and resinous incenses—alongside distinctive fauna, including the colugo or flying lemur. This chapter preserves a concise record of an early Sumatran Islamic state interacting with the wider Indian Ocean trade network prior to regional conflicts with neighboring powers.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official interpreter, Chinese Muslim scholar from Shaoxing, and chronicler of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming maritime armadas that anchored off eastern Sumatra.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Third emperor of the Ming Dynasty who initiated maritime expeditions and received tributary embassies from Aru.

Sultan Husain (fl. 1411): Ruler of Aru recorded in contemporary annals as dispatching tributary envoys to the Ming court.

Sultan Sajak (fl. 15th century): Subsequent monarch of the Deli/Aru lineage noted in regional genealogical traditions.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary expedition scholar whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan provides brief complementary references to Sumatran commodities.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih corroborates details regarding Aru's local society and wildlife.

Wang Ta-yüan (fl. 1330–1350): 14th-century merchant whose earlier travelogue recorded regional textile and forest trades across the archipelago.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Renowned 20th-century Chinese sinologist who edited and collated the authoritative text of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and legal officer who produced the definitive Hakluyt Society translation and geographic apparatus.

Chronology of the Aru–Ming Era

1282: Early envoys from the northeastern Sumatran coast arrive at the Mongol Yuan court.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho visits the northern and eastern coasts of Sumatra, opening direct relations with regional rulers.

1407–1409: Second Expedition calls at coastal ports including Aru and Lambri, presenting gifts of silk and brocade.

1411: The King of Aru sends a diplomatic mission bearing tribute to Nanjing, receiving imperial gifts in return.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Chinese vessels anchor off the Deli River estuary while operating in northern Sumatra.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition; returning ambassadors from Aru and neighboring states are repatriated aboard Chinese ships.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition traverses the Malacca Strait, navigating between Malacca, Aru, and Semudera.

1451: Circulation and compilation of Ma Huan's completed travelogue.

1511–1539: Subsequent regional wars involving Aru, the Sultanate of Malacca, and the expanding power of Aceh.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Ya-lu (Aru / Deli): The historical polity situated along the northeastern coast of Sumatra near the Deli River and modern Belawan harbor (approximately 3°47′N, 98°41′E).
Fresh Water Estuary (Tan-chiang): The mouth of the Sungai Deli, where river water met the ocean tides and formed a protected harbor for ocean junks.
Dry-Land Rice Culture: The practice of shifting cultivation (ladang) in cleared forest patches, producing small reddish grains rather than irrigated wetland paddy.
K'ao-ni Cloth: A regional term for imported or local woven cotton textiles (kain), commonly traded in Sumatran and Bengali ports.
Islamic Identity: Ma Huan notes that both the king and the common people had embraced Islam, observing standard dietary and religious customs.
Flying Lemur (Galeopterus variegatus): Described accurately by Ma Huan as a tree-dwelling beast the size of a cat, possessing membranous skin wings connecting the limbs, which fed on forest fruits.
Su Incense (Lign-aloes): Fragrant resinous heartwood derived from Aquilaria species, harvested in upland Sumatran rainforests.
Chin-yin Incense (Benzoin): The aromatic resin of the Styrax tree (kemenyan), widely gathered in northern and eastern Sumatra for medicinal and ceremonial export.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Maritime Route and Geographic Boundaries

The country of Aru (Ya-lu) was reached by sailing across the Strait of Malacca from the port of Malacca. Aided by favorable winds, the passage across the channel occupied four days and nights. Arriving along the northeastern coastline of Sumatra, ships entered the sheltered roadstead known as the Fresh Water Estuary (Sungai Deli), proceeding upstream toward the settlement where the ruler resided.

The realm occupied an intermediate position on the island: the open sea lay to its north, high forest-covered mountains rose to the south, level lowlands stretched eastward toward the strait, and the neighboring realm of Semudera bordered it to the west.

Society, Customs, and Subsistence

The population of Aru maintained a modest, localized economy centered primarily around fishing and agriculture. Because the terrain was hilly and heavily wooded, farmers did not develop extensive irrigated wet-paddy fields, instead relying on cleared plots in the forests to cultivate dry-land rice. The resulting rice grains were small and reddish, but overall food supplies were stable and easily obtained. Domestic stocks included oxen, goats, chickens, and ducks, which were reared in large numbers.

In matters of religion and social custom, the king and his subjects were Muslims, and Ma Huan observed that their everyday manners were honest and unpretentious. Domestic practices—including matrimonial rituals, funeral observances, language, and everyday clothing—closely mirrored the cultural patterns found across the sea in Malacca and in the ports of Java.

Commodities and Forest Products

Although Aru was a relatively small principality with limited industrial output, its territory produced valuable natural commodities prized in maritime commerce:

Textiles and Provisions: The populace traded in local and imported cotton fabrics, while market surplus in grain, poultry, and dried fish (junker) supported visiting shipping.
Aromatics: The upland forests yielded prized incense woods, notably yellow su incense (lign-aloes) and fragrant chin-yinincense (Sumatran benzoin), which were harvested by interior tribes and brought to the coast for sale.
Fauna: The surrounding rainforests sheltered unusual wildlife, including the flying lemur (colugo). Ma Huan described this creature as an ash-colored beast roughly the size of a cat, equipped with a continuous fleshy membrane running from its front limbs to its hind legs and tail, enabling it to glide between high forest branches without descending to the ground.

Through its strategic position opposite the Malay Peninsula, Aru maintained regular commercial relations with passing fleets and dispatched tributary envoys to the Ming imperial court.

The Country of Su-men-ta-la [Semudera / Pasai]

An Account of the Northern Sumatran Entrepôt from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages of the Ming treasure fleets under Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the northern Sumatran sultanate of Semudera (known historically as Samudra-Pasai, or Su-men-ta-la in Chinese sources) functioned as the premier maritime emporium of western Indonesia. Situated strategically at the northwestern gateway to the Strait of Malacca, the port served as the mandatory assembly and staging point for fleets preparing to traverse the open waters of the Indian Ocean toward Ceylon, southern India, the Persian Gulf, and the Red Sea. In his records, interpreter Ma Huan provides critical documentation of the region's political volatility and direct Ming military involvement. During the fourth expedition (1413–1415), Zheng Ho intervened in a local dynastic crisis, capturing the rebel usurper Sekandar (Su-kan-la) and returning him to China for execution, thereby stabilizing Sultan Zain al-Abidin on the throne. Ma Huan's detailed chapter captures an active Islamic commercial center renowned for extensive pepper cultivation, bimetallic coinage of gold dinars and tin cash, and complex relations with adjacent interior highland populations such as the tattooed inhabitants of Nagur.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition interpreter and Chinese Muslim author whose travelogue provides the most comprehensive Chinese account of Semudera.

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and naval commander who led Ming forces in suppressing the armed rebellion at Semudera in 1415.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming ruler whose foreign policy brought Semudera under direct imperial protection through diplomatic and military interventions.

Sultan Zain al-Abidin (fl. early 15th century): Legitimate ruler of Semudera restored to his throne by Ming military assistance after the defeat of Sekandar.

Sekandar (Su-kan-la, d. 1415): Pretender to the Semudera throne who led thousands of insurgents into open rebellion before being captured by Zheng Ho's troops and executed in China.

The "Old Fisherman" King (fl. early 15th century): Local leader who, according to indigenous tradition recorded by Ma Huan, avenged the former king, governed the kingdom, and married the widowed queen.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Fleet contemporary whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan records trade specifications, weights, and currency exchanges at Pasai.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary who confirmed Ma Huan's accounts of Semudera's urban layout, pepper harvests, and naval anchorages.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Leading modern sinologist who compiled the authoritative critical edition of Ma Huan's text.

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who produced the Hakluyt Society's definitive English edition and maritime notes.

Chronology of the Semudera–Ming Era

c. 1267: Sultan Malik al-Salih founds the Islamic kingdom of Samudra-Pasai, establishing one of the earliest Muslim sultanates in Southeast Asia.

1292: Marco Polo visits Samudra (Sumatra) while accompanying a Mongol princess to Persia, noting early conversions to Islam along the coast.

1345–1346: Moroccan traveler Ibn Battuta resides in Semudera, documenting its active scholarly culture and maritime trade.

1405–1407: First Expedition of Zheng Ho visits Semudera, inaugurating direct diplomatic tributary relations with the Ming Dynasty.

1409–1411: Third Expedition calls at Pasai, presenting gifts of silk and gold to the royal court.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Sekandar launches a violent revolt; Zheng Ho defeats the rebel forces, captures Sekandar near Lambri, and restores the rightful monarch.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition; the imperial fleet divides at Semudera, dispatching separate squadrons toward the Persian Gulf and the Red Sea.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition makes its final outward assembly at Semudera before navigating westward toward Ceylon and India.

1451: Final circulation and compilation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

1521–1524: Portuguese military occupation and subsequent annexation by the expanding Sultanate of Aceh.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Su-men-ta-la (Semudera / Pasai): The kingdom centered around the Krueng Pasai river basin near modern Lhokseumawe in northern Sumatra, from which the name of the entire island of Sumatra eventually derived.

Ta-lu-man Anchorage: The coastal mooring village situated at the mouth of the Krueng Pasai, where ocean-going treasure ships anchored due to strong tidal bores in the estuary.

The Usurper Sekandar: Identified in Chinese chronicles as Su-kan-la , a claimant who seized power following the death of the "fisherman king" until eliminated by Chinese military forces.

Pepper Plantations: The primary commercial crop of Semudera, cultivated extensively against hillsides and traded across the Indian Ocean in standardized weights (bahar).

Durian (Tu-erh-yen): The iconic tropical fruit accurately described by Ma Huan as possessing a foul, piercing outer smell paired with sweet, custard-like white segments.

Gold Dinar and Tin Cash: The dual currency system of Pasai, utilizing small cast pale-gold coins (ti-na-erh) alongside petty tin coins (chia-shih).

Pile Dwellings: Houses elevated on timber stilts up to eight feet above the ground, floored with split palm trunks and partitioned with woven rattan screens.

The Kingdom of Nagur (Na-ku-erh): An inland highland population adjoining Semudera (identified with the Peudada region), whose warriors were marked by three pointed blue facial tattoos.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Approach and the Pasai Estuary

The country of Semudera (Su-men-ta-la), formerly known in Chinese records as Hsü-wen-ta-na , constituted the principal commercial emporium of the Western Ocean. Sailing southwest from Malacca across the strait with a fair wind, ocean-going vessels reached the coastal landing of

Ta-lu-man in five days and nights. From this coastal anchorage, a riverine journey inland toward the southeast for over ten librought travelers to the capital.

The realm occupied an open maritime position: the open ocean formed its northern boundary, high jungle-covered ranges rose to the south and east, while the sea stretched outward to the west. The river estuary was subject to intense marine tides that ebbed and flowed twice each day, generating large swells that frequently endangered anchored shipping.

Political Revolts and Ming Intervention

Ma Huan records a notable local historical tradition concerning the succession of the kingdom. In earlier times, the king was killed in battle by a poisoned arrow fired by the tattooed-face king of neighboring Nagur. Having an infant son unable to avenge his death, the widowed queen publicly vowed to marry any man capable of defeating the enemy and restoring the kingdom's sovereignty. A local fisherman volunteered, successfully mobilized the army, vanquished the Nagur forces, and avenged the fallen monarch. The queen honored her vow, raising the fisherman to the throne as the "old king," whose administration was widely accepted.

Following the fisherman king's death, the royal son assassinated his stepfather and assumed rule. However, the fisherman's son from a previous marriage, named Sekandar (Su-kan-la), fled into the mountains with an armed faction, launching persistent raids against the capital. During the fourth expedition (1413–1415), Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho arrived with an imperial armada. Acting under imperial commands to enforce stability, Chinese soldiers attacked Sekandar's encampments, pursued the rebel force across northern Sumatra as far as Lambri, captured Sekandar alongside his family, and escorted him to China, where he was executed. The grateful sultan thereafter maintained an uninterrupted succession of tributary missions to the Ming court.

Topography, Agriculture, and Natural Commodities

The climate of Semudera was characterized by hot mornings and cool evenings, with malarial conditions prevalent during seasonal transitions. The upland mountains produced rich deposits of sulfur gathered from rocky caverns. While arable land for wet-paddy agriculture was scarce, the populace cultivated dry-land rice in forest clearings, reaping harvests twice a year.

The primary commercial commodity of the country was black pepper. Local farmers maintained extensive hillside gardens where climbing pepper vines produced dense clusters of berries. Once harvested and dried in the sun, the peppercorns were weighed on official steelyards and traded to visiting foreign vessels in enormous volumes, establishing the kingdom as a prime international supplier.

In local markets, fruits were plentiful, including bananas, sugar cane, mangosteens, and jackfruit. Ma Huan took special note of the durian (tu-erh-yen), describing it as a large, spiky fruit with a distinctive, pungent odor resembling rotting meat, yet containing sweet, creamy segments whose roasted seeds tasted like chestnuts. Domestic animals included yellow oxen, goats, and ducks, though caponizing was unknown to local breeders.

Social Hierarchy, Architecture, and Commercial Exchange

The inhabitants of Semudera were devout Muslims, and Ma Huan praised their customs as pure, orderly, and upright. Their spoken language, writing script, wedding ceremonies, and funeral rites closely paralleled those of Malacca.

Dwellings were built on elevated wooden stilts measuring eight feet off the ground, constructed using split coconut and areca-palm wood lashed together with rattan strips, with sleeping and living quarters positioned on the raised platforms. In marketplace transactions, the community used both pale-gold coins (dinar) and tin cash (chia-shih). Commercial weights were standardized, with sixteen liangconstituting a local catty (chin).

Directly bordering Semudera to the west lay the highland territory of Nagur, whose inhabitants lived in a large mountain settlement under their own ruler. The men of Nagur were distinguished by three pointed blue tattoo marks etched into their faces. Though their speech and manners were identical to those of Semudera, their agricultural lands were limited, and they maintained an uneasy peace with their coastal neighbors.

The Country of Li-tai [Lide / Meureudu]

An Account of Northern Sumatra from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages commanded by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the northern littoral of Sumatra featured a sequence of minor coastal principalities operating under the diplomatic and commercial shadow of Semudera-Pasai. Among these was the small realm of Li-tai (identified with Lide, modern Meureudu in the Aceh region), situated along the coastline between the highland territory of Nagur and the western polity of Lambri. In his survey, expedition interpreter Ma Huan documents Li-tai as a subordinate dependency whose elected leader acknowledged the suzerainty of the Sultan of Semudera. Rather than functioning as an independent commercial emporium, the settlement maintained an insular existence supported by a modest agrarian and maritime population that shared the Islamic customs, language, and everyday habits of Pasai. The principal economic significance of the territory lay in its rugged, forested interior mountains, which harbored populations of wild rhinoceroses. Hunters captured these animals to supply precious horns for regional tributary exchange, allowing Li-tai's envoys to join missions dispatched to the Ming imperial court.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition interpreter, Chinese Muslim scholar, and author of Ying-yai sheng-lan .

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions whose armadas patrolled northern Sumatran waters.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who extended the imperial tributary system across Southeast Asian coastal kingdoms.

The Ruler of Li-tai (fl. early 15th century): An elected headman chosen by the local population to administer civil affairs under the suzerainty of Semudera.

Sultan of Semudera (fl. early 15th century): Overlord of the northern Sumatran coast whose court received political submission and administrative deference from Li-tai.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary soldier-chronicler whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan omits an independent notice of Li-tai, making Ma Huan the primary Ming source for the locality.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih corroborates Ma Huan's geographic description of the Meureudu coast.

Tomé Pires (c. 1468–1540): Portuguese apothecary and author of Suma Oriental , who later recorded the port of Lide along northern Sumatra.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Modern Chinese sinologist whose critical collation stabilized the surviving texts of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who produced the Hakluyt Society's critical edition and geographic notes on early Ming voyages.

Chronology of the Northern Sumatran Coastal Environs

c. 1290s: Northern Sumatran coastal ports begin formal conversion to Islam, establishing riverine principalities along regional trade lanes.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho initiates formal tributary relations between the Ming court and northern Sumatran polities.

1409–1411: Third Expedition visits neighboring Semudera and Lambri, consolidating Chinese maritime influence in the area.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Ming forces suppress the rebellion of Sekandar in northern Sumatra, restoring stability to Semudera and its subordinate dependencies.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition calls at northern Sumatran roadsteads to repatriate foreign envoys.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition navigates along the northern Sumatran littoral before making the open-sea transit across the Bay of Bengal.

1451: Final circulation and compilation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan text.

c. 1520s: Rise of the Sultanate of Aceh under Ali Mughayat Syah, absorbing Lide, Pedir, Pasai, and neighboring coastal settlements into a unified empire.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Li-tai (Lide / Meureudu): The northern Sumatran coastal district situated along the Strait of Malacca between Samudra-Pasai and Aceh, centered near modern Meureudu.

Geographical Boundaries: Bordered to the east by the highland territory of Nagur, to the west by Lambri (Aceh), to the south by high interior mountains, and to the north by the open sea.

Elected Monarchy: Ma Huan notes that the local community of three thousand households elected an administrative leader to manage public affairs.

Suzerainty of Semudera: The political subordination of Li-tai to the larger sultanate of Semudera-Pasai, reflecting the hierarchy of coastal Sumatran city-states.

Absence of Indigenous Trade Crops: Unlike neighboring Pasai, the immediate coastal lowlands of Li-tai lacked large pepper plantations or manufactured goods.

Upland Rhinoceros Reserves: The dense forested hills of the interior supported abundant Sumatran rhinoceroses (Dicerorhinus sumatrensis), captured primarily for the valuable export of their horns.

Cultural Uniformity: The spoken dialect, Islamic customs, and social habits of Li-tai were virtually indistinguishable from those of Semudera.

Joint Tributary Embassies: The envoys of Li-tai traveled alongside the diplomatic missions sent by the Sultan of Semudera to present tribute at the imperial court in China.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Situation and Political Vassalage

The country of Li-tai (Lide , corresponding to the modern Meureudu region) constituted a small coastal realm situated along the northern shore of Sumatra. Its borders were clearly demarcated by natural and political barriers: the northern frontier faced the open expanse of the great sea, while dense mountain ranges rose to its south. To its east lay the highland boundary of Nagur (Peudada), and to the west it adjoined the maritime realm of Lambri (Nan-p'o-li , modern Aceh).

The realm supported a population estimated at roughly three thousand families. Rather than being governed by an entrenched hereditary dynasty, the community followed a local custom of selecting a respected man to serve as their king, entrusting him with the management and administration of the country's public affairs. In regional politics, Li-tai held no independent hegemony; it was politically subject to the authority and jurisdiction of the neighboring sultanate of Semudera-Pasai.

Society, Customs, and Forest Commodities

The daily customs, spoken tongue, and social conventions of Li-tai were essentially identical to those observed in Semudera. The inhabitants professed Islam, observing shared religious regulations, dress, and domestic rituals.

The immediate agricultural territory was relatively limited and produced no significant commercial crops or specialized craft manufactures for export. However, the rugged mountain ranges rising to the south supported dense rainforests teeming with wild rhinoceroses. The local ruler regularly organized hunting parties of specialized trackers to enter the mountain valleys, trap the beasts, and harvest their horns, which were valued as medicinal and lapidary luxuries.

Because of its subordinate status within the northern Sumatran political sphere, Li-tai did not dispatch independent naval armadas abroad. Instead, whenever official tributary fleets were organized, the envoys of Li-tai traveled in the company of the diplomatic missions from Semudera, sailing aboard the treasure ships to present rhinoceros horns and local offerings to the Chinese imperial court.

The Country of Nan-p’o-li [Lambri / Atjeh]

An Account of Northwest Sumatra from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch’eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages of the Ming fleet under Admiral Zheng Ho, the kingdom of Lambri (Nan-p’o-li, situated at the northwestern tip of Sumatra around the Aceh and Banda Aceh coastal region) served as the primary navigational landmark and jumping-off point for voyages traversing the open Indian Ocean toward Ceylon and India. Earlier recorded by medieval travelers including Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta as an ancient commercial realm, by the early Ming period Lambri was a modest Islamic polity governed by its own Muslim ruler. Ma Huan’s account highlights both the geographical and economic realities of the settlement: while domestic agriculture was limited and grains were scarce, the area functioned as a major harvesting zone for premium-grade laka-wood and native rhinoceroses. Crucially, Ma Huan documents the nearby island landmark of Mao-shan (Pulau Weh) and the surrounding waters, which served as the essential orientation beacon for Chinese pilots entering the Western Ocean and hosted rich harvesting beds for black tree-coral.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition interpreter and Chinese Muslim chronicler who recorded the physical layout, customs, and products of Lambri.

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and naval commander whose fleets regularly reconnoitered the northwestern coast of Sumatra before setting sail across the Bay of Bengal.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming ruler whose expanding tributary network welcomed regular embassies and tribute shipments from the ruler of Lambri.

The King of Nan-p’o-li (fl. early 15th century): Local Muslim monarch who governed the settlement, maintained elevated wooden residences, and dispatched tributary missions to China.

Sekandar (Su-kan-la, d. 1415): The Sumatran pretender pursued across the northern coast as far as the Lambri territory, where he was captured by Zheng Ho's troops.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Fleet contemporary whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan complements Ma Huan's observations regarding the navigation points of northern Sumatra.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih details the geography and local customs of the Lambri coast.

Wang Ta-yüan (fl. 1330–1350): Fourteenth-century traveler who recorded earlier historical notes on the ports of northern Sumatra.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Prominent modern Chinese sinologist who prepared the critical collated text of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who provided the authoritative Hakluyt Society edition and geographic annotations.

Chronology of the Lambri–Ming Era

1282: The kingdom of Lambri dispatches diplomatic envoys to the Mongol court of Khubilai Khan.

1292: Marco Polo visits Lambri, documenting its local governance, trade in brazilwood, and conversion of coastal ports.

1345–1346: Ibn Battuta stops at northern Sumatran ports, noting regional political hierarchies.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho calls along the northern Sumatran coast, incorporating Lambri into the tributary system.

1407–1409: Second Expedition presents gifts of silk, brocade, and porcelain to the local ruler.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Chinese forces pursue the rebel Sekandar into the Lambri district, capturing him before returning to Nanjing.

1417–1419: Fifth Expedition repatriates returning envoys to Lambri and neighboring kingdoms.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition stages its westward ocean crossing past Pulau Weh toward Ceylon.

1451: Final compilation and circulation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

c. 1520s: Rise of the Sultanate of Aceh, which absorbs Lambri into a unified regional maritime empire.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Nan-p'o-li (Lambri / Lamuri): The historical trading kingdom situated at the extreme northwestern corner of Sumatra, encompassing the coastal district of modern Aceh.

Sailing Course from Semudera: The maritime route steered directly westward along the northern Sumatran littoral, taking three days and nights under favorable monsoons.

Mao-shan (Pulau Weh): A steep, prominent island situated north-northwest of the mainland, functioning as the premier nautical beacon for navigators entering the Bay of Bengal.

Na-mo-li Ocean: The Chinese transcription referring to the open expanse of the Indian Ocean surrounding the northwestern approaches to Sumatra.

Black Coral Harvests: Submerged marine trees (akar bahar) gathered from surrounding shallow reefs, polished to a dark jade-like luster and crafted into beads and buttons.

Lotus-Flower Laka-Wood: A superior variety of aromatic resinous wood (Dalbergia parviflora) prized for its fragrant burning and medicinal properties.

Two-Tiered Architecture: Royal and domestic dwellings constructed upon high timber pillars, utilizing the upper floor for residence while livestock occupied the ground level.

Autonomous Islet Communities: Local populations living at the base of coastal islands where household heads playfully declared themselves independent kings (aku raja).

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Approach and the Maritime Beacon

The country of Nan-p'o-li (Lambri) lay situated at the western extremity of northern Sumatra, accessible from Semudera by sailing due west for three days and nights with a favorable wind. The principality occupied a seaside location bordered by high mountain ridges to the south, while the open ocean formed its northern and western frontiers. To the east, its territory adjoined the boundary of Li-tai.

Roughly half a day's sail to the north-west lay the steep, flat-topped mountain island of Mao-shan (Pulau Weh), which served as the essential orientation land-mark for international fleets voyaging across the open Indian Ocean. Ships arriving from western lands adjusted their sails upon sighting this island to fix their bearings into the Malacca Strait. In the shallow reef waters surrounding the island, local divers gathered branches of fine black marine coral, which

possessed a smooth, jade-like gloss and was fashioned into high-value ornaments, beads, and hat buttons.

Society, Governance, and Royal Living

The population comprised approximately one thousand families, all of whom adhered to the Muslim faith. Ma Huan noted that the people were genuine and honest in character, using cast copper coinage for petty market transactions.

The king of the realm was likewise a devout Muslim. His royal residence was elevated on massive timber columns rising over forty feet in height, arranged in a two-story design. The upper story was enclosed with neat wooden planking and functioned as the living, dining, and sleeping quarters, while the open ground level underneath was utilized to shelter domestic cattle, goats, and poultry. The dwellings of commoners followed a similar elevated structure, identical in construction to the pile houses seen in Semudera.

Natural Resources, Commodities, and Local Lore

Agricultural production was modest, with local rice and grains remaining scarce, although fresh seafood, cattle, and goats were readily obtainable. The economic wealth of Lambri derived primarily from valuable natural forest and maritime products:

Laka-Wood: The forested mountain interior produced the finest grade of laka-wood in the region, designated “lotus-flower laka-wood,” which was highly sought after by foreign traders for incense.

Fauna: Wild rhinoceroses roamed the upland forests, captured for their valuable horns.

Islet Inhabitants: At the base of the mountain island of Mao-shan lived a small settlement of twenty or thirty households. Ma Huan remarked with amusement on their independent temperament: when travelers inquired after their leadership, each man jokingly proclaimed himself to be a sovereign prince (aku raja).

Recognizing the maritime dominance and goodwill of the Ming court, the king of Lambri routinely accompanied Chinese treasure ships and dispatched regular tributary missions bearing prime laka-wood and native commodities to China.

The Country of Hsi-lan [Ceylon]

An Account of the Sacred Isle from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages commanded by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the island of Ceylon (Hsi-lan , modern Sri Lanka) served as a vital maritime and religious pivot in the northern Indian Ocean. Situated along the open oceanic sea lanes connecting Southeast Asia to the Malabar Coast and the Persian Gulf, Ceylon was famous throughout Asia for its rich gem-gravels, coastal pearl fisheries, and sacred pilgrimage destinations. The Ming fleet's engagement with the island was deeply intertwined with both diplomacy and force: during the third expedition (1409–1411), armed conflict erupted between Chinese marines and the local Sinhalese de facto ruler, King Alagakkonara, resulting in the ruler's capture and transport to China. Serving on subsequent expeditions, interpreter Ma Huan recorded the island during a period of relative calm under King Parakramabahu VI of Kotte. His account provides a rich record of the island's dual Buddhist and Hindu religious environment, the sacred footprint on Adam's Peak, extensive royal pearl harvesting, precious stone trading, and maritime approaches via the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition translator, Chinese Muslim scholar, and chronicler who observed Ceylonese shrines, court practices, and gem markets.

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and naval commander who dedicated a famous trilingual inscription (Chinese, Tamil, and Persian) at Galle in 1409.

King Parakramabahu VI (r. 1412–1467): Ruler of the Kingdom of Kotte who reunited the island, maintained formal tributary ties with China, and patronized Buddhist learning.

Alagakkonara (Ya-lieh-k'u-nai-erh, fl. 1409–1411): Powerful regional ruler of the Rayigama kingdom near Colombo, whose hostile confrontation with Zheng Ho ended in his defeat and capture.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who authorized gifts to the island's Buddhist shrines and released the captured Sinhalese royal family back to Ceylon.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Fleet contemporary whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan records the Galle stone monument, local dress, and monetary systems of Ceylon.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary who confirmed Ma Huan's details regarding temple worship, gem beds, and the mountain shrines.

Ibn Battuta (1304–1368/69): Moroccan traveler whose fourteenth-century pilgrimage to Adam's Peak provided a celebrated Western and Islamic description of the island.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Leading Chinese sinologist and historical geographer who established the modern annotated critical edition of Ma Huan's travelogue.

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who prepared the definitive Hakluyt Society edition and geographic gazetteer.

Chronology of the Ceylon–Ming Era

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho visits Ceylon to present offerings, encountering initial friction with local Sinhalese authorities.

1409: The Galle Trilingual Tablet is composed in China in Chinese, Tamil, and Persian, bearing dedications to the Buddha, Siva, and Allah; it is transported to the island during the third expedition.

1411: Armed conflict breaks out between Ming forces and King Alagakkonara; Zheng Ho takes the royal compound, captures the king, and brings him to Nanjing.

1411–1412: The Yongle Emperor pardons the captive ruler and confirms Parakramabahu VI on the throne.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Ma Huan makes his initial voyage to Ceylon, recording the coastal landing at Beruwala.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition calls at southern Ceylonese roadsteads during the outward journey.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition stops at Beruwala before crossing north-northwest to Calicut.

1451: Final compilation and circulation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

1459: Last recorded formal tribute mission dispatched from Ceylon to the Ming imperial court.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

The Naked Peoples (Nicobar and Andaman Islands): The island archipelagos encountered across the Bay of Bengal, inhabited by indigenous communities who lived in caves and foraged along the shore.

Parrot's Beak Mountain (Ying-ko-tsui): Identified with Namunakuli (6,680 feet), a sharp inland mountain peak visible to approaching mariners from far at sea.

Pieh-lo-li (Beruwala / Barberyn): The principal southwestern coastal landing and anchorage for foreign merchant vessels calling in southern Ceylon.

Great Buddha Hall (Fo-t'ang-shan): Identified with Dondra Head, the southernmost point of Ceylon and site of a famous temple complex destroyed in the sixteenth century.

The Sacred Footprint (Adam's Peak): The revered mountain summit bearing a giant indent venerated by Buddhists as the footprint of the Buddha, by Hindus as Siva, and by Muslims as Adam.

Pearl Fisheries: The lucrative oyster beds of the Gulf of Mannar, systematically harvested under royal oversight for distribution in international trade.

Gemstone Deposits: The rich alluvial gem gravels around Ratnapura, yielding rubies, blue sapphires, yellow topazes, and cat's-eyes.

Veneration of the Ox: Strict prohibitions against cattle slaughter, reflecting Hindu and Buddhist sanctity, enforced by severe legal penalties.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Open-Ocean Navigation and Coastal Landfalls

Departing from Pulau Weh at the northwestern tip of Sumatra, Chinese treasure ships navigated across the Bay of Bengal for three days to sight the Nicobar and Andaman Islands. The inhabitants of these islands were described as cave-dwellers who wore no clothing, lived by gathering forest tubers and coastal shellfish, and used no grain or rice.

Steering due west from these islands for seven days, pilots sighted the lofty peak of Parrot's Beak Mountain (Namunakuli), using its silhouette to orient their approach to the island of Ceylon. Rounding the southern headland at Dondra Head (Fo-t'ang-shan), the fleet anchored at the southwest roadstead of Beruwala (Pieh-lo-li), which served as the primary mooring haven for deep-water vessels.

Sacred Topography and Shrines

The southern coast featured remarkable religious sites. At the base of a seaside mountain near Dondra stood an ancient stone sanctuary containing an enormous recumbent brass figure of the Buddha resting on an inlaid wooden couch, surrounded by precious stones and sacred relics.

Further inland rose the soaring heights of Adam's Peak, whose summit touched the cloud line. On its crest rested a sacred natural depression measuring over eight feet long and two feet deep, honored as the primordial footprint of the first ancestor, Adam, or the Buddha. Within the footprint collected clear rainwater, which visiting pilgrims dipped to wash their faces and eyes. The surrounding mountain valleys were renowned across the Orient for yielding extraordinary varieties of gems, including red corundum (rubies), blue sapphires, and translucent precious stones washed down by torrential mountain rains.

Royal Administration, Pearl Diving, and Society

The royal capital was located at Kotte, several miles inland from modern Colombo. The monarch and his court belonged to the Indianized ruling lineage and were devout practitioners of Buddhism, observing strict prohibitions against the slaughter of cows. Violators of this sacred taboo faced capital punishment or the payment of an equivalent fine in gold.

Along the shallows of the sea, the king oversaw extensive pearl-diving grounds. Diving operations were organized regularly, gathering oysters that were placed in coastal retaining enclosures until decayed, allowing attendants to wash out fine pearls under the supervision of state inspectors.

The local population lived in thatched and tiled dwellings, enjoying an abundance of coconuts, which provided oil, sugar, wine, and food. Men shaved their hair except for a bound topknot and draped their lower bodies in patterned silks, leaving their shoulders bare. In commercial markets, transactions were conducted with native gold coins. In exchange for Chinese silks, musk, blue-and-white porcelain, and copper coin, the King of Ceylon dispatched embassies laden with precious gems, pearls, and rare offerings to the Ming court.

The Country of Little Ko-lan [Quilon / Kollam]

An Account of the Malabar Port from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages of the Ming fleet under Admiral Zheng Ho, the port principality of Little Ko-lan (Hsiao Ko-lan , modern Kollam / Quilon on the Malabar Coast of Kerala) served as a vital initial harbor after vessels crossed the Arabian Sea or rounded southern India. Historically celebrated by Nestorian Christians, Arab geographers, and early European travelers such as Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta as a preeminent entrepôt of maritime trade, Quilon by the 1430s was gradually being eclipsed by the rising commercial hegemony of Calicut further north. Ma Huan's account captures this transitional phase of the city's history. His brief survey documents an Indianized kingdom wedged along a narrow coastal plain between the Western Ghats and the Arabian Sea, ruled by a Hindu monarch whom Chinese observers categorized among the So-li (Chola/South Indian) line. Ma Huan notes the kingdom's strict religious taboos regarding cattle sanctity, dietary customs, modest agricultural production of sapan-wood and black pepper, dairy consumption, and the circulation of indigenous gold currency.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition interpreter and Chinese Muslim scholar who visited and surveyed the Malabar coast aboard Zheng Ho's fleet.

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions whose squadrons called at Quilon across several voyages.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming emperor who dispatched the treasure fleets to integrate Indian Ocean ports into the imperial tributary network.

The King of Quilon (fl. early 15th century): Local ruler belonging to the Venad royal dynasty who minted gold coinage and dispatched tribute to China.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Fleet contemporary whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan provides an independent eyewitness notice of Quilon's topography and trade goods.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary who confirmed Ma Huan's observations regarding the local population and trade in his Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih .

Marco Polo (1254–1324): Venetian traveler who visited Quilon (Coilum) in the late thirteenth century, recording its pepper harvests, brazilwood, and multi-confessional merchant enclave.

Ibn Battuta (1304–1368/69): Moroccan traveler who stayed in Quilon (Kawlam), praising its expansive harbor and vibrant Muslim merchant community.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Modern Chinese sinologist whose critical collation established the authoritative text of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who edited the Hakluyt Society's authoritative edition and nautical gazetteer.

Chronology of the Quilon–Ming Era

849/850 CE: Granting of the Kollam Syrian copper plates (Tarissapalli plates), confirming commercial privileges to West Asian merchants and Nestorian Christians.

1279–1282: Yuan Dynasty diplomatic envoys visit Quilon, securing nominal tributary missions to the Mongol court in Khanbaliq.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho calls at Quilon during the outward and return voyages along the Malabar Coast.

1407–1409: Second Expedition presents gifts of silk, brocades, and porcelain to the King of Quilon.

1409–1411: Third Expedition maintains diplomatic presence in Quilon en route to Calicut and Ceylon.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Chinese commercial emissaries acquire local pepper and aromatics.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition; squadrons navigate the Malabar coast between Beruwala, Quilon, Cochin, and Calicut.

1451: Final compilation and circulation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

1502–1503: Arrival of Portuguese fleets under Vasco da Gama and construction of a fortified factory at Quilon.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Little Ko-lan (Hsiao Ko-lan): The Chinese maritime designation for Kollam (modern Quilon, Kerala; approximately 8°53′N, 76°35′E), distinguished from other regional coastal landings.

Sailing Route from Ceylon: Vessels departed from Beruwala (Pieh-lo-li), sailing northwest across the Gulf of Mannar and around Cape Comorin for six days and nights.

Coastal Topography: The territory occupied a narrow strip of coastal strand bordered by the sea to the west and north, with the rising ranges of the Western Ghats to the east.

Religious Classification: Ma Huan categorized the king and people as So-li adhering to Buddhist rites, though modern scholarship recognizes this as a generic Chinese label for South Indian Hindu traditions.

Veneration of the Ox and Elephant: Strict reverence for cattle, including prohibitions against slaughtering cows and the consumption of beef, mirroring customs observed in Ceylon.

Dietary Reliance on Butter: The widespread production and use of clarified butter (ghee) mixed with rice, forming a dietary staple of the Malabar populace.

Indigenous Gold Coinage: The minting of small gold coins (corresponding to the South Indian fanam), reflecting sovereign autonomy prior to northern Malabar conquests.

Malabar Pepper and Timber: Cultivation of black pepper vines and harvesting of sapan-wood (su-mu), exported in exchange for Chinese textiles and ceramics.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Maritime Route and Geographic Setting

To reach the country of Little Ko-lan (Hsiao Ko-lan , Quilon), ocean-going vessels departed from the harbor jetty of Beruwala (Pieh-lo-li) on the southwestern coast of Ceylon. Steering toward the northwest with a favorable monsoon wind, the voyage across the open gulf occupied six days and nights. The territory of the realm formed a narrow strip along the Malabar shoreline, bounded closely to the east by towering mountain ranges, while the expanse of the great sea

adjoined its borders to the west, south, and north. The inhabitants lived in close proximity to the water's edge, oriented primarily toward the sea and coastal waterways.

Monarchy, Religion, and Dietary Rites

The king and his subjects belonged to the South Indian lineage (termed So-li by Chinese chroniclers) and adhered to traditional Indian religious rites. Similar to the beliefs recorded in Ceylon, the populace held profound reverence for both the elephant and the ox, strictly forbidding the killing of cows. In their domestic conventions—including wedding celebrations, funerary procedures, and purification rites—their practices were identical to those observed among the people of Ceylon.

The local diet centered around two meals a day, with a heavy reliance on dairy products. Clarified butter (ghee) was sold in large volumes in the markets, and individuals commonly mixed melted butter into their rice bowls during meals. Livestock included black-haired goats with long legs and large yellow oxen, which were carefully tended.

Agriculture, Currency, and Tributary Commerce

The narrow territory produced moderate agricultural yields, with local gardens providing small quantities of sapan-wood and black pepper alongside modest supplies of vegetables and fruits.

The sovereign minted an independent currency of small cast-gold coins, which were weighed on official steelyards and circulated freely in everyday market exchanges. Although Quilon was a small state whose commercial preeminence was increasingly challenged by neighboring Malabar ports, its monarch regularly welcomed the imperial treasure fleets, selecting local aromatics, timber, and native goods to dispatch as formal tribute to the Chinese imperial court.

The Country of Ko-chih [Cochin / Kochi]

An Account of the Malabar Pepper Port from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages of the Ming fleet under Admiral Zheng Ho, the port principality of Cochin (Ko-chih , modern Kochi on the Malabar Coast of Kerala) emerged as one of China's most strategic commercial and political partners along the southwestern coast of India. Historically overshadowed by the Zamorin of Calicut to the north, the rulers of Cochin actively sought imperial Chinese diplomatic backing. During the fourth expedition (1413–1415), the Ming court granted formal investiture to the King of Cochin (K'o-i-lî), conferring an official seal, a patent of enfeoffment, and royal robes, effectively confirming the realm's sovereign status under Ming suzerainty. Serving aboard the fleet, translator Ma Huan compiled a detailed ethnological and economic survey of the realm. His record captures a stratified South Indian coastal society organized into five distinct social castes—from the noble ruling lineages down to disenfranchised communities—while documenting Hindu temple rituals, the activities of wandering ascetics, an established Muslim merchant class, and specialized mercantile brokers. Economically, the text provides critical insights into the Malabar pepper trade, including seasonal harvesting cycles, standard bulk weighing systems, bimetallic coinage ratios, and valuation formulas for precious pearls and corals.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official interpreter, Chinese Muslim scholar from Shaoxing, and chronicler who recorded the social hierarchy and commercial systems of Cochin.

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions, who formally delivered imperial investiture to the King of Cochin.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who granted Cochin imperial protection, royal regalia, and an inscribed mountain tablet to balance regional power on the Malabar coast.

Keyi Raman (K'o-i-li, fl. 1413–1415): The Perumpadappu Swaroopam ruler of Cochin invested by the Ming court during the fourth voyage.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary soldier-scholar on the expeditions whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan records Cochin's climate, monetary values, and royal gifts.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih corroborates Ma Huan's detailed descriptions of Malabar caste divisions and pepper storage.

Nicolò de Conti (c. 1395–1469): Venetian merchant-traveler who visited Cochin around the same period, providing contemporary European notices of the port.

Duarte Barbosa (c. 1480–1521): Portuguese official whose later sixteenth-century writings documented the same social castes, fanam coinage, and royal succession in Kerala.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Foremost modern Chinese sinologist who prepared the critical collated text of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who produced the Hakluyt Society's authoritative English translation and commercial calculations.

Chronology of the Cochin–Ming Era

1341: A catastrophic flood on the Periyar River alters the coastal coastline, silting the ancient harbor of Cranganore (Kodungallur) and opening the natural harbor basin at Cochin.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho calls at coastal Malabar, establishing initial contacts along the Kerala coast.

1407–1409: Second Expedition visits Cochin while en route to Calicut, presenting silks and porcelain to local chiefs.

1409–1411: Third Expedition maintains diplomatic presence in the port.

1411–1412: Envoys from Cochin accompany returning Chinese ships to Nanjing to solicit imperial backing against Calicut.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Zheng Ho formally invests the King of Cochin, presenting an imperial seal, ceremonial robes, and dynastic protection.

1416: The Yongle Emperor composes an imperial inscription conferring sacred protective status upon the "Mount of Zhenguo" (the guardian mountain of Cochin).

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition repatriates Cochin's resident ambassadors from China.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition calls at Cochin during its outward and homeward Malabar circuits.

1451: Publication and circulation of Ma Huan's completed narrative.

1500–1503: Pedro Álvares Cabral and Vasco da Gama arrive at Cochin, followed by the construction of Fort Manuel, inaugurating Portuguese dominance.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Ko-chih (Cochin / Kochi): The renowned natural harbor and kingdom located on the Malabar Coast of modern Kerala (9°58′N, 76°14′E), situated approximately thirty miles north of Quilon.

Nan-k'un (Nambudiri / Nayar): Chinese transliteration reflecting the elite landholding and ruling classes (Brahmans and Kshatriya/Nayar aristocrats) of Kerala.

Che-ti (Chetty): The mercantile trading caste originating from southern India, specializing in international bullion, gem, and wholesale commodity broking.

Ko-ling (Kling): A term widely used in Southeast Asia and maritime China derived from Kalinga , applied to Tamil and South Indian commission merchants and trade agents.

Mu-kua (Mukkuvar): The coastal seafaring, porter, and fishing caste, subjected by traditional social codes to extreme social exclusion and architectural restrictions.

Cho-chi (Jogis): Hindu ascetics and religious mendicants (yogis), described by Ma Huan as wandering practitioners with matted hair, blown conch shells, and bodies smeared with ashes.

Po-ho (Bahar) and Feng-la (Farsala): Commercial bulk weight units of the Indian Ocean; in Cochin, one bahar was reckoned at 25 farsala (equivalent to 400 Chinese catties or roughly 526 pounds).

Fanam and Tar Coinage: The regional bimetallic currency consisting of the gold fanam (fa-nan) and the petty silver tar(ta-erh), fifteen of which exchanged for a single gold piece.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Maritime Approach and Climate

Departing from the roadstead of Little Ko-lan (Quilon), ships sailing toward Cochin steered along the mountain-backed coastline to the northwest, completing the passage in one day and night with a favorable monsoon. The port was anchored in a protected natural haven beside the Arabian Sea, bordered to the east by the mountain spine of the Western Ghats and linked by inland waterways and coastal roads to neighboring regional territories.

The climate was hot throughout the year, without frost or snow. The calendar was characterized by distinct seasonal cycles: intermittent rain showers began during the second and third lunar months, followed by torrential monsoon downpours during the fifth and sixth months that turned city streets into rushing waterways. By the seventh month, the heavy rains ceased, giving way to clear, dry weather through the winter.

Social Stratification and the Five Castes

Ma Huan observed that the population of Cochin was structured into five distinct social groups:

The Ruling Lineage (Nan-k'un): The aristocratic and priestly orders to which the king and nobility belonged. Men of this rank shaved their heads, wore sacred threads across their shoulders, and held hereditary monopolies over governance and high religious office.

The Muslims: A large community of resident foreign and local Muslim merchants who managed extensive overseas maritime commerce and maintained their own religious structures.

The Chetties (Che-ti): Wealthy property-owners and wholesale merchants who handled the collection, appraisal, and trade of precious gemstones, pearls, and aromatics.

The Klings (Ko-ling): Commission merchants, brokers, and market agents who coordinated wholesale transactions between foreign sea captains and local suppliers.

The Mukkuvar (Mu-kua): The laboring coastal class of fishermen, dockworkers, and woodcutters. They were subjected to strict sumptuary restrictions: their dwellings could not exceed three feet in height, they were forbidden from wearing garments below the knee, and they were required to prostrate themselves or retreat from the roadway upon the approach of high-ranking persons.

Court Life, Religious Ascetics, and Temple Worship

The monarch and ruling elite observed Hindu court traditions. The king wrapped his head in yellow and white cloth, leaving his upper torso bare while securing embroidered silks and sash bands around his waist. In his residential compound stood a dedicated sanctuary housing a cast brass deity, flanked by a basin of lapis lazuli and a sacred well. Daily dawn worship was signaled by sounding bells and drums, after which water drawn from the well was poured over the sacred image. The grounds and walls were coated with clarified cow-dung wash, and the monarch and attendants rubbed sacred ash across their foreheads and limbs as a mark of devotion.

The text also highlights the presence of wandering religious mendicants (Cho-chi , or Jogis). These devotees allowed their hair to grow uncombed and matted with butter, smeared their

bodies with white ash, and carried large sea-shells that they sounded continuously as they moved from house to house receiving offerings of rice and coin.

The Pepper Economy, Currency, and Market Valuation

The kingdom's wealth centered almost entirely on the cultivation and export of black pepper. The vines were grown in extensive hillside gardens throughout the interior. Once harvested and dried, the pepper was purchased by local wholesale buyers and stored in secure brick and mud godowns to protect against fire and theft until foreign fleets arrived.

Wholesale pepper was traded using standardized units: twenty-five feng-la (farsala) constituted one po-ho (bahar), equivalent to four hundred Chinese catties. Visiting merchants purchased this bulk measure for ninety to one hundred local gold coins, valued at five Chinese ounces of silver.

The sovereign minted an independent currency of high-purity gold coins (fa-nan), weighing slightly more than one Chinese fen. For smaller market exchanges, the mint issued thin silver coins (ta-erh), fifteen of which exchanged for one gold piece. Chetties and gem traders utilized steelyards and scales with precise mathematical calculations, determining the price of pearls and polished coral beads based on exact weight.

Through its dedicated alliance with the Ming throne, Cochin maintained regular diplomatic contact, dispatching royal embassies and local commodities to China aboard the returning treasure ships.

The Country of Ku-li [Calicut / Kozhikode]

An Account of the Great Malabar Mart from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century voyages of the Ming dynasty treasure fleets under Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the port city of Calicut (Ku-li, modern Kozhikode on the Malabar Coast of Kerala) served as the primary western terminus and principal operational hub in the Indian Ocean. Ruled by the Hindu dynasty of the Zamorin (Samutiri), Calicut was celebrated across maritime Asia as the foremost international clearinghouse for commodities moving between East Asia, India, the Persian Gulf, the Red Sea, and the Horn of Africa. Diplomatic engagement began during the first expedition (1405–1407), when the Ming court granted imperial patents, robes, and a stone memorial pavilion to commemorate tributary ties. Ma Huan's detailed survey offers an extraordinary record of the city's cosmopolitan governance, where Hindu royal authorities shared civil and administrative leadership with prominent Muslim officials to foster regional stability. His chapter provides invaluable documentation of cross-cultural commercial pacts, communal dietary pacts between Hindus and Muslims, meticulous price-fixing ceremonies conducted between foreign factors and local brokers, advanced finger-reckoning mathematics, the bimetallic monetary system of gold fanams and silver tars , and the social hierarchy governing the Malabar coast.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition interpreter and Chinese Muslim scholar whose firsthand observations provide the fullest Chinese account of Calicut.

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions, who erected an imperial commemorative stele at Calicut in 1407.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign who designated Calicut as the chief Western Ocean partner and received numerous Calicut embassies.

Samutiri (Zamorin / Sha-mi-ti-hsi, r. 1405–1407): Sovereign of Calicut who welcomed the first Chinese expedition and accepted imperial tributary honors.

Mana Vikraman (Ma-na Pieh-chia-la-man, acc. 1407): Successor ruler formally instituted with imperial honors during the second Ming expedition.

The Two Muslim Shahbandars: Senior administrative chiefs of Calicut who managed municipal affairs, customs revenues, and foreign mercantile relations under the Zamorin.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Fleet contemporary whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan records parallel observations on Calicut's markets, topography, and coin usage.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Expedition secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih corroborates details regarding the bilateral contract agreements and port administration.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Renowned Chinese sinologist who collated the surviving versions of Ma Huan's text into an authoritative critical edition.

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British scholar and translator who prepared the Hakluyt Society's critical edition, commercial tables, and geographic notes.

Chronology of the Calicut–Ming Era

1403: The Yongle Emperor dispatches envoy Yin Qing to initiate formal diplomatic relations with the Malabar Coast.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho reaches Calicut; the Zamorin accepts imperial investiture and dispatches return envoys to Nanjing.

1407–1409: Second Expedition arrives to celebrate the accession of Mana Vikraman, erecting an imperial pavilion and commemorative stone tablet.

1409–1411: Third Expedition utilizes Calicut as its primary Malabar fleet anchorage.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Calicut serves as the forward base from which Ming squadrons first advance to Hormuz.

1417–1419: Fifth Expedition visits Calicut while escorting Malabar and Arabian ambassadors back to their homelands.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition calls at Calicut; secondary fleets detach westward toward Aden and East Africa.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition; Chinese squadrons make extended stopovers at Calicut, with a detached mission proceeding directly to Mecca.

1451: Final circulation and compilation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

1498: Arrival of Vasco da Gama's fleet at Calicut, inaugurating European armed intervention on the Malabar Coast.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

The Great Country of the Western Ocean (Hsi-yang Ta-kuo): The formal Chinese geographic title acknowledging Calicut's status as the paramount emporium of the Indian Ocean.

The Commemorative Tablet: A stone inscription and sheltered pavilion erected by Chinese commanders in 1407 to celebrate perpetual friendship between China and Calicut.

The Matrilineal Succession System (Marumakkattayam): The Kerala legal and inheritance tradition where royal succession bypassed the sovereign's biological son to pass to the eldest son of his sister.

Communal Dietary Pact: A long-standing municipal understanding whereby the Hindu monarch and population refrained from slaughtering cattle or consuming beef, while Muslim inhabitants and officials abstained from pork.

Finger-Reckoning (Kanakku): The South Indian mathematical practice of mental arithmetic using the joints of the fingers and toes to calculate complex sums with unerring speed without an abacus.

Bilateral Handclasp Contract: A commercial convention where Chinese fleet officials, local ministers, and Chetti brokers fixed exchange values by joining hands under a cloth, recording values in duplicate contracts.

Trial by Boiling Oil: An ancient judicial ordeal where accused persons asserting innocence plunged fingers into boiling oil, followed by bandage sealing and subsequent inspection.

Ten Uses of the Coconut Palm: Ma Huan's catalog of the multiple economic utilities of the coconut, spanning roofing thatch, edible oil, toddy wine, sweet syrup, timber, shell bowls, and coir maritime ropes.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Approach and the Paramount Malabar Port

The realm of Calicut (Ku-li) was designated by Chinese observers as the "Great Country of the Western Ocean," representing the primary commercial clearinghouse of southern Asia. Departing from the harbor anchorage of Cochin, vessels followed the coastal contour toward the northwest for three days to reach Calicut. Bordered to the west by the open Arabian Sea, the

realm was bounded by Honavar to the north, Cochin to the south, and linked across the mountain passes of the Western Ghats to Coimbatore in the east.

Early in the Yongle era, the Ming court recognized the sovereign with an official imperial mandate, a silver seal, and ceremonial patents of honor. A sheltered pavilion was erected housing a carved stone tablet, commemorating the historic harmony and mutual prosperity uniting the realms across thousands of liof ocean.

Dual Governance, Caste Organization, and Religious Harmony

The sovereign, titled the Zamorin, belonged to the Kshatriya and Nayar ruling lineages (categorized as Nan-k'unby Chinese chroniclers) and practiced traditional Hindu rites. The succession to the throne followed matrilineal lines (Marumakkattayam): royal authority descended not to the monarch's own son, but to the son of his sister, based on customary inheritance law.

Municipal and civil governance was characterized by power-sharing. The administration was led by two principal Muslim chiefs who oversaw municipal order, foreign trade, and the port customs house. The wider population was organized into five defined social orders: the ruling and priestly class (Nan-k'un), the Muslim merchants, the property-holding mercantile Chetties (Che-ti), the commission brokers (Ko-ling), and the lower-caste fishermen and laborers (Mu-kua).

Communal harmony was maintained through a mutual dietary agreement: the Hindu king and his subjects strictly prohibited the slaughter of cattle or consumption of beef, while the Muslim populace honored this sanctity and abstained from pork. Within the royal palace, the monarch maintained a dedicated brass deity sanctuary where daily dawn worship was performed with sacred water, and ash was rubbed across the foreheads and limbs of attendants.

Commercial Infrastructure, Contracting, and Mathematics

Calicut operated as an efficient and regulated international free port. When the treasure ships arrived, royal officers and local Chetti merchants met with Chinese envoys to determine the exchange rate of trade goods. To formalize agreements, the parties sat together, grasped hands in a ceremonial handclasp, and drafted duplicate written contracts that were strictly observed throughout the trading season.

Ma Huan expressed deep admiration for the merchants' mathematical precision: using only the twenty digits of the hands and feet without paper or abacus, accountants calculated intricate sums and valuations with complete accuracy. Transactions were settled using gold fanams (pa-nan) and small silver tars (ta-erh), alongside standardized steelyard units where twenty liangformed a local catty and two hundred catties constituted a bulk po-ho (bahar).

Local Products, Justice, and Cultural Life

The surrounding countryside supported extensive plantations of black pepper and coconut palms. Ma Huan detailed the coconut's versatility, noting its application in producing culinary syrup, fermented wine, edible meat, lighting oil, vessel-building timbers, household bowls, and coir fiber spun into strong ship ropes. The markets featured fine Indian textiles, prized kerchiefs, and rich assortments of jewels, pearls, and coral beads shaped by Chetti lapidaries.

The legal framework avoided flogging with bamboo, instead utilizing fines, property confiscation, limb amputation, or capital punishment for major offences. In disputed litigations, authorities administered trial by ordeal: the accused placed their fingers into a caldron of boiling oil, which was subsequently bandaged and sealed for several days; if the flesh emerged uninjured, the individual was acquitted amid musical celebrations and community honors.

Before the Chinese armada took its departure, the King of Calicut commissioned a splendid ceremonial girdle—crafted from fifty liang of fine red gold drawn into delicate threads and set with pearls and precious gems—dispatching royal ambassadors to accompany the fleet and present the gift as tribute to the Chinese court.

The Country of the Liu Mountains [Maldive and Laccadive Islands]

An Account of the Coral Archipelagos from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the early fifteenth-century maritime expeditions led by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, the coral atolls spanning the Maldives and Laccadives—designated by Chinese chroniclers as the Liu Mountains (Liu-shan , derived from the Sanskrit dvīpa / Divehi dhiwa)—formed an indispensable mid-ocean crossroads. Positioned along the oceanic highways running between Southeast Asia, southern India, the Arabian Peninsula, and the East African coast, these low-lying atolls served both as vital navigational markers and as specialized production centers for unique marine commodities. Although earlier Chinese geographies often grouped the archipelagos into mythical zones of treacherous "weak waters," interpreter Ma Huan provided a remarkably detailed and empirical survey of the islands. He identified eight primary atolls and anchorages (including Male and Minicoy), cataloging a strictly Islamic island society governed by maritime sultanates. Ma Huan documented the region's unique material culture: the construction of sewn-plank watercraft built without iron nails, extensive exports of dried bonito fish (kalu-bili-mas) and coir fiber, rich harvests of ambergris, and the processing of marine cowry shells, which circulated as standard small-denomination currency across Southeast Asia and Bengal.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition translator, Chinese Muslim scholar from Shaoxing, and author of Ying-yai sheng-lan .

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions, whose detached squadrons visited the Maldives across several voyages.

Sultan Haji Hassan III (fl. c. 1420–1421): Monarch of the Maldives during the period of early Ming diplomatic contact.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Third Ming sovereign whose trade and tributary initiatives incorporated remote oceanic island networks.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary soldier-scholar whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan borrowed data on the islands and described their trade goods.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Fleet secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih preserves parallel, occasionally superior orthographic readings of Maldivian atoll names.

Ibn Battuta (1304–1368/69): Celebrated Moroccan traveler who resided in the Maldives as a chief judge (qadi) in the 1340s, leaving the most famous medieval Islamic account of the archipelago.

Pyrard de Laval (1578–1621): French navigator shipwrecked in the Maldives whose later seventeenth-century account confirmed the island traditions, coir rope industries, and cowry trade recorded by Ma Huan.

Feng Ch'eng-chün (1887–1946): Foremost 20th-century Chinese sinologist who prepared the authoritative collated edition of Ma Huan's work.

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British jurist and sinologist who produced the Hakluyt Society translation, identifying the Chinese transcriptions of the individual atolls.

Chronology of the Liu Mountains–Ming Era

1153: King Koimala converts to Islam, adopting the title Sultan Muhammad al-Adil and establishing Islam as the state religion throughout the Maldives.

1343–1346: Ibn Battuta resides in the Maldives, documenting the export of cowries, dried fish, and coconut cordage.

1405–1407: First Expedition under Zheng Ho traverses the northern Indian Ocean; navigational routes past the archipelagos are charted.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; secondary squadrons visit the Maldives to survey their ports and acquire ambergris and cowries.

1417–1419: Fifth Expedition; Maldivian envoys travel to China to render tribute and receive imperial gifts.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition calls at northern atolls while conducting detached missions to the Persian Gulf and Africa.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition; the fleet uses the archipelago's northern waters as a critical sailing fairway between Ceylon and Calicut.

1451: Circulation and compilation of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

1558: Portuguese colonial incursions establish a temporary fortified garrison at Male.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Liu-shan (The Liu Mountains): The collective Chinese name for the Maldives and Laccadives, where Liutransliterates the Sanskrit/Prakrit dīpa or dīva (island).

Kuan-hsü-liu (Male / Official Island): The political seat of the Sultan of the Maldives, transcribed in text variants as Kuan-jui-liu.

Sewn-Plank Vessels: Traditional ocean crafts (dhows / dhonis) constructed without iron nails, using coconut coir cords threaded through drilled holes and caulked with pitch.

Cowry Currency (Hai-pa): Marine money cowries (Monetaria moneta) harvested in immense quantities from reef shallows, piled into rotting heaps, and exported to Bengal and Siam as currency.

Ambergris (Lung-hsien-hsiang): Sperm-whale secretion found floating in the surf or washed ashore, highly valued in Ming China for perfumery and exchanged at parity with silver.

Dried Bonito Fish (Ma-chiao-yü): Known locally as kalu-bili-mas or "Maldive fish," boiled, smoked, and sun-dried into hard fillets for wide export across maritime Asia.

The "Weak Waters" (Jo-shui): Ancient Chinese mythological geographic concept applied to deep oceanic doldrums and treacherous currents surrounding isolated oceanic shoals.

Coir Cordage: Strong, rot-resistant marine rope manufactured from the soaked and beaten fibrous husks of coconuts, sought after by visiting international fleets for rigging.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Setting and the Eight Atolls

Departing from Pulau Weh (Mao-shan) off northern Sumatra, ships sailing southwest across the open sea reached the archipelagos in roughly ten days under favorable winds. The local inhabitants referred to the region as Tieh-kan (transliterating Divaor the island realm), while Chinese navigators termed them the Liu Mountains, though the terrain consisted entirely of low-lying coral atolls and sandy islets rising only slightly above sea level.

The text specifies eight major island centers with established populations and local chiefs:

Sha-liu: Mulaku (Meemu) Atoll.

Jen-pu-chih-liu: Fadiffolu (Lhaviyani) Atoll (the “Gubati” of Arab rutters).

Ch’i-lai-liu: Tiladummati Atoll (transcribed erroneously in some versions as Ch’i-ch’üan).

Ma-li-ch’i-liu: Minicoy Island, the cultural stepping-stone between the Maldives and the northern Laccadives.

Chia-pan-nien-liu: Kalpeni Atoll in the Laccadive group.

Chia-chia-liu: Sacrifice Rock or northern shoals.

An-tu-li-liu: Androth Island.

Kuan-hsü-liu: Male, the administrative capital and continuous residence of the reigning sultan.

Beyond these eight primary centers, tradition held that thousands of narrow islets and treacherous sandbanks dotted the waters, giving rise to maritime warnings concerning perilous ocean channels where disabled ships could drift helplessly into ocean currents.

Society, Attire, and Islamic Faith

The ruler, nobility, and general populace were devout adherents of Islam, characterized by Ma Huan as possessing excellent, upright customs. Both men and women were of slightly dark complexion. Men wrapped their heads in white cotton turbans and draped waistcloths around their lower bodies, while women wore light, short tunics, broad waist-wraps, and large cotton shawls that covered their heads and veiled their faces when stepping outside. All social ceremonies, marriages, and funeral rites strictly observed Islamic jurisprudence.

The soil of the coral atolls was sandy and impoverished, precluding the cultivation of rice, wheat, or inland vegetables. The populace sustained itself through fishing, foraging, and the extensive harvesting of coconut groves, importing grains from abroad.

Marine Technology and Maritime Commodities

Despite their lack of metallurgy, the islanders demonstrated exceptional craftsmanship in utilizing marine resources:

Ship Construction: In building sea-going boats, craftsmen used no iron nails. Planks were fitted together, bored with small holes, and securely stitched using cords spun from coconut coir, after which the seams were sealed tight with melted resin and pitch to withstand heavy ocean swells.

Ambergris: Fishermen harvested floating masses of ambergris (lung-hsien-hsiang) washed ashore or cast up on reefs. This prized substance was purchased by visiting merchants for its equivalent weight in refined silver.

The Cowry Trade: The shallows yielded vast quantities of money cowries (hai-pa). Inhabitants gathered them into immense heaps along the shore, letting the soft tissue decay in nets before washing the clean shells, which were loaded onto transport vessels and exported as currency to Siam and Bengal.

Coconuts and Dried Fish: Coconut palms provided food, sweet nectar, wine, shell cups, and abundant fibers that were twisted into rot-resistant ropes sought after by foreign merchant shipping. Fishermen also processed large quantities of bonito, cutting the dark fish into thick fillets that were sun-dried and exported throughout the Indian Ocean under the name “liu fish”.

Textiles and Coinage: Local weavers produced delicate, finely embroidered silk and gold-threaded kerchiefs that commanded high prices in foreign ports. The king issued a small silver coin for everyday commerce.

Detached treasure ships of the Ming armada visited the islands across multiple expeditions, purchasing large cargoes of ambergris, coconuts, and cowries, while the Sultan of the Maldives dispatched regular embassies bearing island gifts to the imperial court.

The Country of Tsu-fa-erh [Dhufar / Zafar]

An Account of Southern Arabia from the Ying-yai Sheng-lan (1433)

Ma Huan

Translated by J. V. G. Mills · Edited by Feng Ch'eng-chün

PART I: CRITICAL APPARATUS

Contextual Headnote

During the later expeditions commanded by Grand Eunuch Zheng Ho, Ming naval detachments crossed the western Arabian Sea to establish direct diplomatic and commercial relations with southern Arabia. Among the principal ports visited was Tsu-fa-erh (Dhufar, modern Zafar/Salalah in the Sultanate of Oman), which served as the epicenter of the global frankincense trade. Prior to the arrival of the Chinese fleets, direct Far Eastern maritime contact with southern Arabia had been rare, with commodities passing primarily through intermediaries in Calicut or Hormuz. Drawing from his firsthand observations during the voyages of 1421–1422 and 1431–1433, Ma Huan produced the earliest comprehensive Chinese account of Dhufar. His narrative records a devout Muslim society governed by an independent sultan, describing local court processions, Friday congregational liturgies, urban perfuming rites, and specialized monetary systems. Economically, the account highlights the harvesting of wild Boswellia resin (frankincense) and dragon's-blood gum, which local authorities exchanged directly for Chinese porcelain and silks before dispatching formal tributary embassies to the Ming imperial court.

Dramatis Personae

Ma Huan (fl. 1413–1451): Official expedition interpreter, Chinese Muslim scholar from Shaoxing, and author of Ying-yai sheng-lan .

Zheng Ho (1371–1433): Grand Eunuch (Sanbao Taijian) and Commander-in-Chief of the Ming naval expeditions, whose detached squadrons visited southern Arabian harbors.

The Sultan of Dhufar (fl. early 15th century): Independent South Arabian ruler who welcomed the imperial Chinese mission, instituted public trading orders, and dispatched return embassies to China.

Eunuch Chou Man (fl. 1421–1423): Ming fleet commander who led secondary squadrons westward from northern Sumatra toward Arabia and the Red Sea.

Yongle Emperor (Zhu Di, r. 1402–1424): Ming sovereign whose expansionist maritime policy initiated direct state trading with Arabian ports.

Xuande Emperor (Zhu Zhanji, r. 1425–1435): Sovereign who authorized the seventh voyage, under which final missions called at Dhufar.

Fei Hsin (b. 1388): Contemporary scholar-soldier on the expeditions whose Hsing-ch'a sheng-lan includes parallel observations on Dhufar's trade and natural products.

Kung Chen (fl. 1433): Fleet secretary whose Hsi-yang fan-kuo chih details the ceremonial welcomes and incense commerce of southern Arabia.

Ibn Battuta (1304–1368/69): Moroccan traveler who visited Dhufar (Zafar) in the fourteenth century, recording its coastal trade, mosques, and horse exports.

J. V. G. Mills (1887–1987): British sinologist and jurist who translated and annotated the Hakluyt Society edition of Ma Huan's travelogue.

Chronology of the Dhufar–Ming Era

c. 1330s: Ibn Battuta resides in Zafar, describing its export of Arab steeds and frankincense to the Malabar coast of India.

1405–1411: Early Ming naval expeditions establish regular anchorages at Calicut, gathering commercial intelligence on the ports of southern Arabia.

1413–1415: Fourth Expedition; Chinese vessels advance past India to Hormuz, opening direct routes across the Arabian Sea.

1421–1422: Sixth Expedition; Ming squadrons divide in Sumatra, with detached ships sailing directly to Dhufar and Aden.

1431–1433: Seventh Expedition; Chinese emissaries trade at Dhufar, acquiring extensive shipments of frankincense, aloe, and exotic animals.

1433: Returning ambassadors from Dhufar and neighboring Arabian realms arrive at Peking, presenting local products to the imperial court.

1451: Circulation and formal publication of the Ying-yai sheng-lan .

c. 1507–1520: Arrival of Portuguese armadas in the Gulf of Aden and Arabian Sea, altering trade routes throughout southern Arabia.

Editorial Footnotes (Apparatus)

Tsu-fa-erh (Dhufar / Zafar): The historical coastal district and port located on the southern coast of the Arabian Peninsula in modern southern Oman (Salalah region; approximately 17°00′N, 54°06′E).

Sailing Course from Calicut: Junks departed the Malabar Coast steering northwest across the Arabian Sea, completing the open-ocean transit in roughly ten days with favorable winds.

Frankincense (Ju-hsiang): The aromatic gum resin obtained from incisions in the bark of Boswellia sacra , harvested exclusively in southern Arabia and the Horn of Africa.

Dragon's-Blood (Hsüeh-chieh): A deep red resin derived from species of Dracaena (Dracaena cinnabari), collected for medicinal, dyeing, and liturgical uses.

Friday Market Suspension: The civic custom of halting all public commerce before midday on the Muslim Sabbath to allow the populace to bathe, perfume themselves, and gather at the mosques.

Pi-li and So-nai: Tartar-style reeds and the double-reed oboe/shawm (surnay), blown alongside military pipes during royal processions.

Gold Tanka (Tang-chia): Struck gold coinage of the regional Arabian sultanate, used for high-value commercial transactions alongside fractional copper coins.

Topography of the Plain: A fertile coastal strip lying directly between the open sea to the southeast and rising limestone mountain ranges to the northwest.

PART II: ESSAY & HISTORICAL ACCOUNT

Geographic Approach and the Arabian Coastline

The country of Tsu-fa-erh (Dhufar) was situated along the southern coast of the Arabian Peninsula, facing the Arabian Sea. Vessels departed from the international anchorage of Calicut on the Indian coast, setting a course toward the northwest across the open ocean. Driven by a favorable monsoon, the crossing was accomplished in ten days and nights. The port was established on an open coastal plain flanked by the sea to the southeast and steep, barren mountain ridges rising to the northwest. The settlement lacked defensive stone walls or surrounding suburban moats, with dwellings built along the maritime plain against the foothills.

Society, Court Ceremony, and Religious Observances

The ruler and his subjects were devout adherents of Islam. The inhabitants were characterized by Ma Huan as tall and robust in stature, with dignified bearing, disciplined manners, and honest speech.

The sultan dressed in fine foreign white cloths wound around his head as a turban, while his body was clothed in long robes embroidered with blue floral silk patterns or woven with gold thread. On his feet he wore shallow leather shoes or soft foreign riding boots. When the ruler stirred abroad, he traveled in a covered sedan-chair or mounted an Arab charger, escorted by structured ranks of cavalry, war camels, and elephants, accompanied by attendants playing whistles, pipes, and oboes (so-nai). The common men wore long robes, turbans, and leather shoes, while domestic and marriage rituals conformed strictly to Islamic law.

Religious observance governed municipal routines. On the weekly day of worship, all commercial stalls and marketplace trading were ordered suspended before midday. Men and women of every station bathed thoroughly, rubbed their faces and limbs with distilled rose-water and scented oils, and dressed in clean robes. Carrying portable earthenware burners smoking with sinking incense and sandalwood, the populace processed through the market streets toward the central mosques, leaving the thoroughfares fragrant with aromatics after prayers concluded.

Forest Products, Trade Negotiations, and Imperial Diplomacy

Dhufar's primary commercial significance lay in its natural abundance of high-grade frankincense (ju-hsiang). The resin was harvested from small trees resembling elm shrubs, whose bark was slashed to allow the sap to bleed and harden into fragrant nodules, which were gathered and brought to coastal warehouses for sale. The uplands also supplied quantities of crimson dragon's-blood resin, harvested for medicine and dyeing.

When the Ming treasure fleet arrived in port, imperial envoys conducted public readings of the emperor's proclamations and presented gifts of fine textiles to the sovereign and his officers. The sultan subsequently issued directives authorizing local merchants to bring their frankincense, dragon's-blood, camels, and rare ostriches to exchange for Chinese porcelain and silk-gauze fabrics. For everyday internal transactions, the kingdom utilized a gold tanka alongside small copper coins.

Upon the conclusion of trade, the Sultan of Dhufar selected extensive shipments of frankincense and indigenous gifts, dispatching royal ambassadors aboard the Chinese vessels to render homage and formal tribute at the imperial court in China.